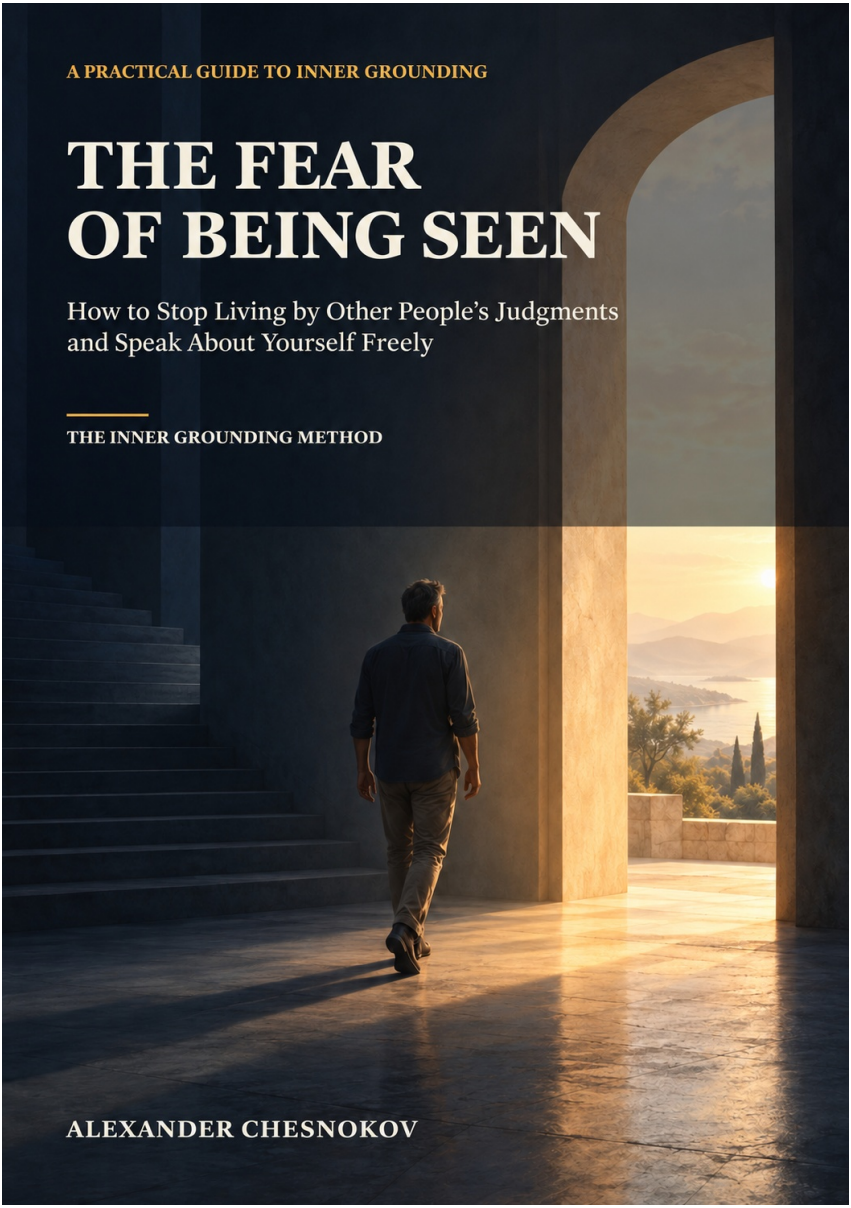
A PRACTICAL GUIDE TO INNER GROUNDING

THE FEAR OF BEING SEEN

How to Stop Living by Other People's Judgments and Speak About Yourself Freely

THE INNER GROUNDING METHOD



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Preface. Why I Wrote This Book

I was once afraid even to introduce myself in a networking chat.

Not speaking before a packed auditorium. Not walking onto a stage beneath bright lights. Simply writing a few sentences about who I was, what I did, and how I could help.

The thoughts came immediately:

> *"This event is not for me."*
>
> *"I'm not good enough yet."*
>
> *"What am I going to say?"*
>
> *"What kind of expert am I?"*

Sometimes I never made it to the event at all. I did not talk about my ideas, meet new people, or show them what I could offer.

Now I calmly write posts, record videos, speak and talk about my project. Not because I once became a perfect speaker and stopped making mistakes. I found an inner grounding and stopped making other people’s opinions the main proof of my own worth.

That's why I wrote this book.

Why This Book Matters

I want to show you that the fear of being seen can be worked through.

You do not have to spend years forcing yourself to speak through intense tension, experiencing every presentation, post, or introduction as an ordeal. You can understand why an ordinary

situation triggers such a powerful reaction, where the shame and expectation of rejection come from, and what helps you return to your adult self.

In this book, I bring together my personal experience, the Inner Grounding Method, and practical ways to become more visible in social media, public speaking, and professional life.

I have not found another source that brings these subjects together in quite this way. I will not claim that no similar book has ever existed. What matters more is that these pages contain my lived experience, told honestly and without pretending to be a perfect expert.

You will read stories from my life: the fear of publishing my first post, the endless preparation, the inner critic, the tension in my body while speaking, and the years it took before I allowed myself to speak openly.

Alongside the explanations, you will find questions and practical steps. They can help you notice your own reactions, understand the danger your fear is trying to protect you from, and experiment with a different response.

Understanding the mechanism can itself be an important first step. But I cannot promise that every reader will get the same result or become completely free of fear after a few exercises. Each person has a different history, a different depth of pain, and a different pace of change.

Who This Book Is For

First of all, I wrote it for experts, professionals and entrepreneurs.

A person may have valuable knowledge, a useful tool, a strong idea, or a promising project. But if they are afraid to make themselves visible, no audience will ever know about it.

A professional needs to communicate discoveries and practical methods. An entrepreneur needs to talk about the project, speak at events, meet people, and look for partners and investors.

I once had an idea that I told no one about. I decided, “It probably isn’t for me.” I did not approach the people who might have supported the project. Later, someone else developed a similar idea.

An idea alone is not enough. People also need to hear about it.

This book is for anyone who still remains in the shadows but keeps looking for a way out—someone who has not lost hope of learning to speak calmly about themselves and their work.

If you recognize yourself, you and I are talking about the same thing.

Why I’m Sharing My Experience

You don't have to trust me right away.

You do not have to treat every thought in this book as absolute truth. Read it, compare it with your own experience, and test the suggested tools in real life.

What I can offer is something I have genuinely lived through. I went from being afraid to write a few lines about myself to speaking calmly in public, meeting new people, and talking openly about my own project.

I am grateful to the people I learned from and to the courses, training programs, and practical tools that helped me understand myself more deeply. I tested what I learned in my own life, combined it with other approaches, and gradually developed the Inner Grounding Method.

This journey allowed me to apply what I had learned, shape the Inner Grounding Method, and begin writing.

But there's another big reason this book came along: I finally let myself write it.

Before You Begin

I invite you to look at the fear of being seen from a different angle.

You do not have to become fearless overnight. What matters is that fear no longer gets to decide whether people will ever see you, your abilities, and your work.

Allow yourself to be visible as a professional. Begin revealing your abilities and sharing the value you can genuinely offer.

This book may be your first step.

Part I. Why Being Seen Feels Dangerous

Chapter 1. The Poem I Forgot

For a long time, I was afraid of public speaking.

It did not take a large stage, a microphone, or an unfamiliar auditorium. That came later. A classroom, a handful of people, or simply having to speak while everyone looked at me was enough.

Before I went to the front, my voice would begin to shake. A text I knew seemed to disappear. My mind went blank, and I wanted only one thing: to finish as quickly as possible and go somewhere no one was looking at me.

For years, I thought I simply did not know how to speak in public. Other people could stand up, speak calmly, and sit down again, while I seemed to have been built differently. Before I had said a word, I had already humiliated myself in my imagination, let everyone down, and received my sentence.

I later realized that this fear had begun long before I ever stood at a classroom board.

Kindergarten

When I was in the middle group at kindergarten, I had to recite a poem. I practiced it for a long time. The adults made me repeat it and kept checking whether I remembered it.

But the message around me was constant: I was doing badly. I could not remember anything. I was stupid, and the other children could do it better.

A child cannot step back and calmly reason:

> *“This is only one adult’s opinion. Perhaps this person is tired, irritated, or simply using an unhelpful way of teaching.”*

No, of course not.

Children often believe what adults tell them—especially the adults they love and depend on. If your mother says that you are stupid and will fail, you assume that she must be right.

I stood up to recite the poem—and forgot it.

Everything I had practiced disappeared from my mind. I felt ashamed—not merely disappointed that I had forgotten a line, but convinced that something was wrong with me. Other children could do it. Once again, I could not.

The story ended quickly. But inside, it didn't really end.

An Old Scene in a New Setting

Then came the walk to the front of the classroom. I had to answer the teacher, read a passage, or speak in front of the class. The setting changed, but my reaction remained much the same.

I had not even stood up yet, but the voices had already begun:

> *"You'll forget it again."*
>
> *"Everyone will see you're stupid."*
>
> *"You'll be embarrassed again."*
>
> *"You'll let everyone down."*

The people in front of me could be completely different. They knew nothing about that kindergarten experience and might not have intended to judge me at all. But my mind seemed to start playing the same old movie.

There I am as a little boy.

There is the poem.

There is the adult who seems to decide whether I am good or bad.

And there is the danger of once again feeling stupid, rejected, and unwanted.

My body did not listen to my adult explanations. I could tell myself, “Pull yourself together. Nothing terrible is happening,” but my voice still shook and the words still vanished.

That was why the familiar advice to “pull yourself together and face your fear” did not help me.

I still went to the front of the classroom. I said what I had to say. Sometimes it even went well. But inside, it still felt like an ordeal I had to force myself through.

When Fear Becomes Part of Your Identity

When this happens repeatedly, a person may stop saying, “I am afraid of public speaking.” Instead, they begin to say, “I cannot speak in public,” “I am not that kind of person,” or “It just isn’t for me.”

Fear gradually becomes part of the way a person sees themselves.

Do you recognize yourself? Perhaps you have also mistaken an old fear for a permanent personality trait.

I grew up and my circumstances changed, but fear found new places to stop me. Today, being seen can mean:

write a post;

record a Story or a short video message;

publish a video;

Talk about your work;

name your price;

Express an opinion with which someone may disagree.

You open the publishing window and read the text for the third, tenth, or twentieth time. You make one small correction, and then another. Eventually the post becomes so polished and correct that the author has disappeared from it. At least, it seems, there is nothing left for anyone to criticize.

I went through this too. You sit over the text wondering whether you have said too much about yourself. Have you started acting like an expert? Should you remove the sentence saying that you can help? Perhaps it would be safer to leave only your name and profession. Safe. Modest. And completely unclear why anyone should contact you.

Whenever I did publish a post, I immediately checked the reaction. Who had liked it? What had they written? Had anyone said I was talking nonsense? One unpleasant comment could throw me off for a long time. The post was already online, but inwardly I was still standing in front of a group of people, waiting to be judged.

Have you experienced this? You have already taken the step, but instead of feeling pleased, you wait to see how other people will judge you.

I can laugh about it now. At the time, it was not funny at all.

What I Mean by Inner Grounding

The change did not begin when I learned to speak perfectly. Nor did it begin when I convinced myself that everyone would finally like me.

No one can be liked by everyone. There are billions of people in the world, and each mind creates its own version of me. One person sees confidence; another sees arrogance. One interprets my

directness as honesty; another as harshness. All of this can happen before people truly know me at all.

I began to change when I stopped making other people’s opinions the main proof of my own worth.

For me, inner grounding means remaining on my own side even when someone disagrees, criticizes me, or fails to understand. It does not mean pretending to be unaffected or forcing myself forward while everything inside tightens. It means noticing what feels so frightening in this moment and returning to my adult self.

The person in front of me today is not my mother from that childhood experience. It is not my kindergarten teacher. It is not a classroom that seems to determine whether I have the right to be myself.

I'm an adult today.

If anyone doesn't like my post, I'll survive.

If someone calls my video nonsense, my value will not disappear.

If I forget a phrase during a performance, it will be a forgotten phrase, not proof that I am stupid.

It sounds simple. Yet there can be a great deal of work between understanding something intellectually and feeling it inside.

I Didn’t Become a Different Person

Today I can speak in public, write posts, and record videos without that old level of fear. I can even fool around in front of the camera and post a video that offers no great benefit to humanity. My inner controller would never have allowed that before: if you are going to face an audience, you must be serious, correct, and preferably brilliant from the very first moment.

I did not become someone who never cares. An unpleasant reaction can still hurt. I may disagree with criticism or feel nervous before an important talk.

The difference is that fear no longer decides for me.

I no longer need everyone’s permission before I speak. I can rely on myself, understand why I am stepping forward, and remain human. I can make a mistake, phrase something imperfectly, stop, and begin again.

That is what being seen means to me. It is not about being loud, constantly putting yourself on display, or playing the part of a confident expert who never has doubts. It is the ability to be visible without abandoning yourself.

A Short Practice

Think of one situation in which you wanted to put yourself out there but stopped yourself. Do not take on your whole life at once. Choose one specific episode:

did not publish the post;

did not record the video;

stayed silent at the meeting;

did not name the price;

turned down the speaking opportunity.

Write down the answers to five questions:

What exactly was I going to do?

What reaction from other people frightened me?

What would that reaction mean for me?

Whose voice does my inner critic sound like, and what earlier experience does it bring to mind?

What can I say to myself as an adult now?

You do not have to rush onto a big stage and prove that you are fearless. First, notice that the person stopping you may not be the audience in front of you, but an old story that once convinced you that being seen was dangerous.

Once you notice this, a small pause becomes possible.

And within that pause, you can choose your next step instead of disappearing in the familiar way.

Chapter 2. I’m Not Ready Yet

My fear of being seen did not always look like fear.

It often looked like responsibility, thorough preparation, and high standards.

I wanted to become a psychologist and write about the things I understood. But before I could begin, I believed I needed to learn more.

Then a little more.

And then a little more after that.

I was constantly promising myself, “I will start when I am ready.” The problem was that readiness never arrived.

But before I published my first post, resistance took over. Everything seemed badly written: here I sounded too bold; there I acted as if I were already an expert. Better remove this sentence—and the promise of a result as well. Safer still, leave only my name, the word “coach,” and a list of my qualifications. Modest, safe, and completely unclear why anyone should contact me.

I could call it perfectionism. But for me, that word is too broad and too neat. Beneath the perfectionism lived the same fear: if I put myself out there and did something wrong, people would see that something was wrong with me.

When Learning Becomes a Hiding Place

I was afraid that someone would come to me and I would fail to help. They would leave with nothing, and it would become obvious that I was not a real professional.

The solution seemed obvious: I needed to know more.

Do you recognize these thoughts? “I need to learn more. Then I will be ready.”

So I decided I needed another degree. I wanted to write, talk about psychology, and work with people, which meant—at least in my mind—that I first had to master every professional term. Only then would I have the right to be visible and call myself an expert.

After my first university degree, I completed additional training in psychology. I expected to finally feel ready to put myself out there, work with clients, and talk openly about what I did.

My fear of failing to help a client did become weaker. I had more knowledge and understanding. But the fear of being seen did not disappear; it simply changed form again. Now I was afraid of a live audience.

I Know the Material, but I’m Afraid to Speak

Speaking to one person felt manageable. But when five, ten, or twenty people were in the room, tension began to rise inside me.

I had to hold the group’s attention, speak in a way that kept people listening, and lead an online class, exercise, or meditation. The fear was always close by: “I will make a mistake. I will say something wrong. They will dismiss me. They will decide I am talking nonsense.”

I took public-speaking courses and learned how to carry myself, structure a talk, and work with my voice and an audience. The training was useful. But the fear remained.

This taught me an important distinction. If you lack public-speaking skills, knowledge, training, and practice can genuinely help. But you can also know exactly what to do and still expect danger inside. Another course may add tools without reaching the reason your body tightens, your voice shakes, and you want to hide.

That was exactly what happened to me.

Five Years of Training

I spent about five years searching for confidence and inner grounding. During that time, by my estimate, I spent around two hundred thousand rubles on psychologists, training, and various practices. I studied about ten techniques, worked with different professionals, and tried a range of approaches.

Some of that training was useful. It gave me a professional foundation and helped me gradually assemble the Inner Grounding Method. I came to understand the connection between thoughts, feelings, bodily reactions, and behavior more clearly. I learned not to suppress discomfort, but to notice it and explore the threat behind it.

But there was another side to this journey. Learning became a way to postpone action a little longer: one more course, one more technique, one more certificate—and then I would finally be ready. Yet readiness still did not come.

During those years, I lost more than money. I lost time and enjoyment in my work. I could have begun practicing sooner, become more visible, built an audience, written a book, and launched my own programs. For several years, I charged roughly 1,500 to 2,000 rubles per hour. As my experience and inner confidence grew, I was able to raise my consultation fee several times over.

Of course, I cannot know exactly how my path would have unfolded if I had started earlier. But I know this: I would have gained more practical experience and more real contact with people.

How Fear Disguises Itself as Responsibility

Not all learning is avoidance. Sometimes we truly do lack knowledge—especially when the work involves another person's health, safety, money, or other serious consequences. A lack of competence should not be disguised as a fear of being seen.

But the real gap in knowledge can usually be described accurately:

> *"I do not know how to conduct an initial consultation."*
>
> *"I need more practice working with groups."*
>
> *"I do not understand the limits of my professional competence."*
>
> *"I need to learn how to explain this tool in plain language."*

Then you can choose focused training, learn the skill, and test it in practice.

Fear speaks more vaguely:

> *"I'm not good enough yet."*
>
> *"I need to know more."*
>
> *"I'll be completely confident first."*
>
> *"Once I earn one more qualification, then I will begin."*

This kind of learning has no finish line because the problem is not a specific gap in knowledge. The person is searching for a certificate that will grant internal permission to be visible and protect them from every possible criticism.

Does this sound familiar? "Once I earn one more qualification, then I will begin." Then another course appears, along with another reason to wait and another reason to doubt yourself.

But there is no such document.

What Changed for Me

It took me about six months to work through my fear of public speaking and my discomfort with calling myself a psychologist and crisis psychologist. At first, a voice immediately rose inside me: “What kind of psychologist are you? They will ask who you think you are. How can you claim to have a project of your own?”

The test for me was a professional event attended by about twenty people. I had to introduce myself and talk about myself.

I stood up and calmly said that I was a psychologist—a crisis psychologist—with experience and a project of my own. I explained that I wanted to develop the Inner Grounding Method and create a school.

My hands did not shake. My voice neither trembled nor faded. My body did not tense up. I did not try to guess what other people thought of me.

After that, I attended two more similar events. Each time, I was able to speak about myself calmly.

For me, that was the real test of the result—not a comforting thought rehearsed at home in front of a mirror, but a new response in a real situation.

You Can Start Where You Are

My conclusion is simple: it is never too early or too late to become visible. That does not mean presenting yourself as an expert in everything or promising people the impossible.

You can honestly talk about the level at which you are:

> *"I'm just getting started."*
>
> *“This is what I have learned so far.”*

“I can help with this, but I do not work with that yet.”

“This is my experience and my perspective.”

At work, being visible helps you explain your value, ask for a raise, take responsibility, and show initiative. In business, it helps you meet people, network, talk about your product, and find partners and clients.

Confident speech alone does not prove that a product is good. But if you cannot explain the real value of your product, people may never discover it.

Everyone has strengths. The people around you are not required to guess what yours are.

A Self-Check

If you still feel that it is too early for you to be seen, answer these four questions in writing:

What specific knowledge or skill do I lack?

Where can I learn it, and how long will it take?

What small step can I already take with my current level of preparation?

What am I truly afraid of: harming someone because I lack competence, or hearing another person’s judgment?

If you can name the gap, address it and practice the skill.

If no specific answer comes and all you hear inside is “I am still not good enough,” then fear may once again be hiding behind your desire for more training.

In that case, you do not need another certificate. You need an honest look at the danger you are trying to protect yourself from.

Chapter 3. The Inner Critic

The post was finished. Only the simplest step remained: pressing “Publish.”

But at that exact moment, an inner conversation would begin:

> *“Read it one more time.”*
>
> *“Let’s do it tonight.”*

Evening came, and a new suggestion appeared: “Better wait until morning.”

By morning, there seemed to be no reason to rush. I could publish it tomorrow or in a few days. The post would not become any worse. Probably.

I read the text again, changed sentences, and removed anything that might sound too bold or wrong. I checked for mistakes, worried that I had written nonsense, and imagined that people might mock the post.

Then important tasks suddenly appeared. I needed to clean, go to the store, or get some work done. At that exact moment, everything became urgent. First the tasks, then the post.

Does this sound familiar? The text is ready, but your finger still cannot press the button.

The Inner Critic Rarely Speaks Directly

The inner critic does not always shout, “You are stupid. You will fail.” Sometimes it sounds perfectly reasonable and even caring:

> *"Slow down."*
>
> *"We need to improve a little bit more."*

"First, check it again."

Today is not the best day to publish.

Each sentence sounds logical on its own. But if you still cannot publish after the tenth review, the real problem may no longer be the quality of the text.

There were other questions behind my checks:

"What will people think?"

"What will they write?"

"How many likes will there be?"

"What if there are no likes at all?"

“What will my friends and family think of me?”

I was not afraid of the button or the post itself. I was afraid of what might happen after I published it.

Fear Doesn’t End After You Publish

When I finally pressed “Publish,” one of two reactions usually followed.

Sometimes I immediately put down my phone and found something else to do. I did not want to see the response. I imagined that unpleasant comments were about to appear, and for a while it felt safer not to know.

At other times, the opposite happened. I checked my phone constantly: How many likes were there? Had anyone commented? Was there any reaction at all?

It was a strange cycle. First I could not publish because I feared the response. Once I did publish, I either ran away from my phone or could not put it down.

A notification about a new comment affected me especially strongly. My body tensed before I had even read it. The thoughts were already there:

"What if it's negative?"

"What do I say?"

Negative comments did appear from time to time. Anger and fear rose inside me, and I wanted to abandon everything and never write again.

What did you think and feel in such situations?

When a Comment Feels Like Proof

I now understand that it was not only the comment itself that hurt me. The meaning I assigned to it hurt much more.

Someone might disagree with a single thought in my post. But inside, I heard something very different:

"You wrote nonsense."

"You're saying the wrong thing."

"You have no right to talk about it."

"You can't write."

"You're stupid."

“Why did you put yourself out there in the first place?”

One comment stopped being one person’s opinion. It became proof that something was wrong with me.

And here the inner critic already said familiar words from childhood:

“Do not put yourself out there.”

"Keep your head down."

"Silence is gold."

"Don't shame us."

“Keep your head down and stay quiet.”

What Is the Inner Critic Trying to Protect?

For a long time, I saw my inner critic as an enemy that stopped me from writing and putting myself out there. Later, I recognized that it was trying to play another role.

It was trying to protect me.

It was not the most helpful form of protection, of course. But it tried to shield me from what my mind considered dangerous: criticism, shame, judgment, and rejection.

As a child, I heard from my mother that it was better to stay quiet, keep my head down, and avoid embarrassing the family. To a child, the words of an important adult are not merely an outside opinion. That adult represents safety, love, and survival itself.

I was afraid of saying too much, shaming my family, and feeling guilty. Beneath that fear was an even deeper threat: the people close to me would turn away, I would be left alone, and I would not survive.

A child does not reason, “Mom is irritated right now, so her judgment may be unfair.” The child is more likely to conclude, “If Mom says this, something must truly be wrong with me. I should stay quiet so she will not reject me.”

That conclusion helped me adapt at the time. Years later, it continued operating in situations where the original danger no longer existed.

A social media post became the adult version of walking to the front of the classroom. An unfamiliar commenter seemed like someone who had the power to decide whether I was good or bad. My inner critic would say, “Don’t publish it. Don’t take the risk. It is safer to stay invisible.”

When Someone Else’s Voice Becomes Your Own

The inner critic does not necessarily sound like a mother, teacher, or anyone else from the past. In my case, it sounded like my own inner voice.

But those rules did not appear from nowhere.

After hearing “keep your head down” many times, you no longer need anyone else to say it. You repeat it to yourself and may sincerely mistake it for caution, responsibility, or a desire to do good work.

That is why simply ordering yourself to “stop being so critical” rarely helps. The critic is not trying to start a conversation. It is trying to prevent an experience that once felt painful.

In my case, it was guarding against rejection, shame, and the feeling that I did not matter.

When I Stopped Believing the Critic

The change began with a simple question:

> *“When did I first feel this way?”*

I began looking not only at the thoughts that appeared before publishing, but at the feeling beneath them. Using the Inner Grounding Method, I entered that experience and returned to

childhood situations in which I had heard my mother say similar things.

Then I saw it more clearly: the inner critic was not giving me an objective assessment of the text in front of me. It was repeating an old warning about danger.

When I was little, criticism from a close adult truly felt threatening. I could not calmly disagree, leave, or rely on my own judgment. I depended on adults and accepted their words as the truth about me.

But now I'm an adult.

An unpleasant comment may hurt me today, but it cannot take away my home, my life, my right to speak, or my freedom to choose my path. I can accept useful feedback, disagree with someone’s judgment, delete an insult, or choose not to argue at all.

The main thing is that I no longer need to turn the opinion of another person into a verdict on myself.

During that inner work, I addressed my younger self in my imagination:

> *“You may not take those words personally. It's the other person's thoughts about you, not the whole truth about who you are. Then your life depended on adults. You have grown up and you can be on your side.*

For me, it was a return to adulthood. I stopped arguing with the critic and began to understand the old pain he was protecting me from.

Another Person’s Opinion Does Not Define My Worth

Now in situations related to publications and the story about myself, the former internal critic does not control me. I don’t need to check the text ten times just to get internal permission to speak.

I leave other people the right to have an opinion about me. There are billions of people on Earth, and I can't control what images appear in their heads.

Some people will like my text, some will not. One person will see my honesty in me, another will see my sharpness. It is their perception, which is made up of their own experience.

My value cannot rise from a like every time and disappear from an unpleasant comment. What matters to me is whether I am on my side, whether I understand why I am speaking, and whether I consider myself worthy of the right to be seen.

I am me. I'm the only one. I am needed, important and valuable to myself.

This does not mean that any criticism should be ignored. There may be useful feedback. But now I can evaluate the content of the remark without turning it into proof of my own stupidity or uselessness.

How to Talk to Your Inner Critic

If an inner critic stops you from publishing, speaking, or talking about yourself, don’t rush to fight him. Try to understand first what he is protecting you from.

Take one particular situation and answer several questions in writing.

What Am I About to Do?

Not "to appear at all," but specifically:

"I want to publish this post."

"I want to record a story."

“I want to talk about my work.”

"I want to tell you the cost of the service."

What Is the Worst I Expect to Happen?

Don’t stop with the answer “I will be criticized.” Ask me further:

“And if I get criticized, what does that mean about me?”

Perhaps there will be answers:

"I'm going to feel stupid."

"They think I'm weak."

"I'm rejected."

"No one will need me."

What Do I Feel, and Where Do I Feel It in My Body?

Don't try to remove the alarm immediately. First notice it: tension in the chest, compression in the stomach, the desire to close the page, put down the phone or urgently clean.

Sometimes at this stage it becomes clear that it is not the text. The text just pressed the old button.

When Did I First Feel This Way?

The memory may appear immediately, later or not at all. You don’t have to make up an appropriate child story. It is important to be honest about what really comes.

If you remember the situation, look: whose words did you take for the truth about yourself? What was dangerous to you at that age?

What decision have you made - to keep quiet, to keep your head down, to be comfortable, to check everything or not to start at all?

What Is Different Now?

Remind yourself of today's reality:

> *"I'm an adult now."*
>
> *"Another's disagreement does not determine my worth."*
>
> *"I can stand the lack of likes."*
>
> *"I don't have to answer the insult."*
>
> *"I can correct a mistake if I'm really wrong."*

What Small Step Can I Take from My Adult Self?

You don't have to go on a big stage right away, you can post one post, you can record a short video, you can give a thought, you can show a text to someone who's safe next to you.

The goal is not to prove my courage at any cost. The goal is to have a new experience: I can be seen, face other people's reactions, and still remain on my own side.

If during such work there are too strong feelings, heavy memories or a condition that is difficult to cope with on your own, it is better to seek help from a psychologist or other suitable specialist.

The critic is not your whole self.

Thoughts may say, "Shut up," "Stay low," "You're not good enough," but thought isn't a fact, and it's not all of you.

The inner critic may have emerged as a way to keep you out of pain, and maybe that protection was really needed once, but today you can test whether the old anxiety is consistent with the current situation.

Do you recognize his familiar voice, what is he trying to protect you from right now?

Sometimes the first step toward being seen is not silencing the critic, but finally hearing the fear behind it and reclaiming your right to decide from your adult self.

Chapter 4. The Price of Invisibility

For a long time, I measured the cost of being seen only by what might go wrong.

I could be criticized.

I could be rejected.

I could make a mistake in public.

Those risks felt immediate and vivid. The cost of remaining invisible was quieter, so for years I barely noticed it.

I kept feeling that my real life was about to begin: just one more course, one more qualification, and then I would finally put myself out there and speak openly about my work.

Years passed. I still did not feel that I had earned the right to be seen.

You probably haven't given up on your business either, you're just going to start for years.

The Project That Was Always Almost Ready

I tried to launch my own project twice, and it took about five years to launch.

The project kept changing names. I added more information, searched for new practices, and returned to studying. Each time, I found a reasonable explanation for why it was still too early to begin:

> *“We need to get a more accurate name.”*
>
> *“A few more practices should be added to the program.”*
>
> *"I don't have enough knowledge yet."*

"I need to get another diploma."

From the outside, it looked like a lot of preparation, but it didn't make the project come alive, it was still the stuff on the computer and the thought in my head.

At some point, I had a basic course ready, and I got a degree in retraining, and I got the right to tailor and run the program, and the basics were put together, and you could talk about the course and invite people.

But even then, I postponed the launch.

The next question was, “What if I don’t succeed?”

And again, something had to be improved.

What I see now is that the name change, the endless addition of materials, and the search for new learning were not just about quality work, they helped me to avoid the risk of real action.

Until the project is launched, it's impossible to evaluate, no one will refuse, no one will criticize or say that they do not need it, but no one will be able to come.

What I Could Have Gained Over the Years

Sometimes I think about how my journey might have turned out if I had started earlier.

I might already have a community, more followers, and many more hours of practice, and I could get to know partners earlier, recruit clients, increase the cost of work, and earn a higher income.

I even found myself thinking that I could make several times as much money, but honestly, it's impossible to prove. Nobody knows what I would get or how many mistakes I made along the way.

To be more precise, I would have had more real experience.

Instead of just thinking about the launch, there would be meetings with people, instead of a program that no one has seen, there would be feedback, instead of guessing whether it will work or not, there would be real results, mistakes, and the possibility of making a difference.

That's what I've been depriving myself of by being invisible.

The price of invisibility isn't just lost money; it's practice, dating, skills, audience trust, and years in which people can become more visible in what they do.

The Envy We Do Not Like to Admit

I looked at coaches, teachers and coaches who boldly talked about themselves, started programs and gathered an audience.

And envied them.

Sometimes, along with jealousy, there was devaluation, and I thought, "What are their practices? Mine are deeper and more effective."

It was a convenient thought. It made me feel better for a few minutes than someone who did things that I didn't dare to do.

I felt angry. Why were people choosing them when I believed my methods were stronger? Why did they have large audiences, clients, and launched products while I had neither an audience nor a functioning project?

Now I realize that my reasoning about the superiority of my own practices was a personal assessment, not a proven fact, and that other people had the advantage of going out and giving people the opportunity to get to know their work.

My knowledge may have seemed valuable to me, but if no one knows about it, no one can decide whether it is right for them or not.

What did you think and feel when you saw the success of people who decided to come before you?

When You Feel Like Giving Up

Those comparisons did not inspire me to launch my project. More often, they left me discouraged.

Inside, it sounded:

> *"I'm stupid."*
>
> *"I'm not getting anywhere."*
>
> *“No one needs me with my knowledge and methods.”*

I shifted my attention to something else. I returned to employment, focused on business, or found a new project. My mind seemed to say, “Do not go there. It is dangerous. You will fail anyway.”

For a while, I felt better. I could stay busy again without facing the pain of my unrealized potential directly.

Eventually, disappointment appeared in those other activities as well. I was still drawn to working with people. I loved explaining, teaching, sharing what I knew, and watching someone begin to see their situation differently.

I returned to my project, began doing something again, encountered the fear, and left once more.

It became a cycle: the work I loved, fear, retreat, disappointment in another job, and another return.

The Work I Loved Still Found a Way Out

At one point, I started a building-materials business. It was a completely different field, yet it became one of the places where I first began to make myself visible.

In the mornings, I gathered my colleagues and gave short talks. I shared ideas and things I had learned. It may not have been perfect, but in those moments I felt more alive.

The same thing happened in conversations with people I knew. An ordinary conversation would quietly turn into a consultation. I began sharing what I had learned about abandonment, feeling unwanted, rejection, and the fear of being seen.

Officially, I was doing one kind of work, while an important part of me kept trying to do another.

Disappointment remained in the background: I was not realizing my potential or fully doing the work that brought me joy. I had no audience and no clients, even though working with people was what I wanted most.

Gradually, I felt like I wasn't living my life.

I could keep telling myself that everything still lay ahead. But life does not pause while a person prepares to become themselves.

The Moment I Began Coming Back to Myself

One of the important steps for me was volunteering at the Time to Live Charity Foundation.

I supported young people who had lived through difficult circumstances, visited addiction-treatment facilities, and gave lectures. Once again, I could work with people, speak publicly, and share my experience.

This was not a major launch or a successful business venture. But it was real action. I was no longer only preparing and thinking; I was meeting people and doing the work.

Gradually, I began working with my fear of failure and my fear of being seen. I recorded Reels and other videos, wrote posts, and

published them. Through these actions, I began to feel that I was finally expressing an important part of myself.

I am currently building a new project around the Inner Grounding Method. It does not yet provide a large income, so I may combine it with part-time employment or another business.

But I no longer want to give all my time to other work. I deliberately reserve some of my energy and attention for this project.

I used to believe that the work I loved either had to produce a good income immediately or be abandoned for something more reliable. Now I see another path: secure the income I need while continuing to build my own work alongside it.

Perhaps it will grow more slowly. But I will not abandon it again.

Money Is Not the Only Measure of a Life

I want to make money off my project. It would be unfair to pretend that money doesn't matter to me.

For me, happiness is not limited to income, prestige, a career, an apartment, or a car. You can have all the outward signs of success and still wake each morning to do work that does not make you feel alive.

For me, happiness is about being able to fulfill my potential, working with people, and enjoying the process.

I believe income can grow as the work develops. But I no longer want to postpone life until I have more money, perfect conditions, and complete confidence.

Full confidence may never come, and time will pass.

How to Measure the Price of Invisibility

People usually see the risks of action clearly: I may be criticized, someone may say no, or the project may fail to make money.

The risk of inaction is less visible because its consequences unfold slowly. Today you do not publish the post. Tomorrow you do not record the video. A week later, you turn down an introduction. A year later, you discover that you are still standing in the same place.

Look not only at your fear of being seen, but also at the price you are already paying to remain invisible.

Answer five questions in writing:

How many years have I postponed the work I want to do?

What experience have I not gained during this time?

Which relationships, clients, or opportunities have I turned away from?

How does waiting affect my inner state and the way I see myself?

If nothing changes, where will I be in three years?

Do not punish yourself with fantasies about the millions you might have lost. We cannot know how much we would have earned or what results we would have achieved.

But you can look honestly at something else: how much time has passed, and whether you gained the experience that originally led you to begin studying.

The First Step Does Not Have to Be Big

Awareness that life is finite can be frightening. I suggest using that awareness not to pressure yourself, but to create clarity.

Life is not endless. You can roughly consider how many years you have already lived and how much time may remain—not to make

yourself anxious, but to stop treating your deepest wishes as something that can be postponed forever.

You can start small.

publish one post;

record a short Reel or Story;

Tell one person about your work;

attend a small networking event;

offer one simple service that falls within your current competence.

Fear can appear as thoughts, emotions, and bodily reactions. The experience is real, but it does not always mean that the present situation is truly dangerous.

You do not need to build a large community immediately or prove that you are successful. The first step serves another purpose: to gain a new experience and discover what actually happens.

Alongside the anxiety, you may also feel satisfaction: “I finally did what I wanted to do.” That new experience gradually teaches the mind that being seen can hold not only danger, but also interest, meaning, and aliveness.

Remaining invisible may once have protected you from criticism and rejection. But while it protects you from possible pain, it also cuts you off from people, experience, and the work you love.

The question is not only what might happen if you allow yourself to be seen.

Ask the other question as well: What will happen to your life if you still do not begin?

Part II. Why Old Fear Gets Triggered Today

Chapter 5. The Old Alarm and the Old Movie

I don't think there's any fear.

I step in front of the audience and begin speaking with confidence and energy. Then I lose my place in the presentation, forget a thought, or stray from the plan I prepared.

And my body changes before I can safely assess the situation.

The palms start to sweat, the movements become stiff, the voice becomes tense, the thoughts that just a minute ago were free, begin to get confused.

Inside, it sounds like:

> *"I said something wrong."*
>
> *"I said it wrong."*
>
> *"How will the audience react now?"*

There's another way, the listener asks a question, and I can't answer it right away, and there's a pause, and the body gets tense, and the thoughts get even more confused, and the excitement and energy that I started with disappears.

After a while, the condition may level out, but one small malfunction has already turned inside into a danger signal.

That was the way I used to be before I started working with the inside.

What the Audience Was Supposed to Do

The forgotten fragment of the presentation itself was not the main problem, but rather the script that instantly popped into my head.

I imagined that the audience would notice my mistake. Someone might smirk; someone else might ask a pointed question to expose me as an impostor.

Inside, there were already estimated estimates:

> *"He doesn't know anything."*
>
> *“You picked up a little superficial knowledge and decided to teach everyone else.”*
>
> *“He has no experience or practice.”*

I haven’t heard the reaction yet, but I’ve been mentally exposed.

I might have had a very friendly audience in front of me who were interested in the talk, but my internal anxiety system was like, you know, I didn't see them, and it was showing another movie, which was old and familiar.

What did you think and feel when you were in front of other people?

The Morning That Filled Me with Shame

One of the episodes of this old movie took place in kindergarten.

I wore very short short shorts and an old short tie at morning, and I didn't like the way I looked, and I didn't do very well either.

After the talk, my mother made it clear that I had disgraced her again, and I can't put every word back to it, but as a child, I heard the main thing: she was ashamed of me.

When I was a kid, I was very thin.

> *"Legs are like matches."*
>
> *"Hands are like matches."*

When I was insecure, she could laugh, and when she was dabbling and saying the usual childhood nonsense, she would hear:

"Shut your mouth."

"Don't embarrass me."

"Don't be ridiculous."

Gradually, I linked free expression to the risk of being ridiculed and shamed by a loved one.

The child is dependent on the adult, fed, protected, cared for, so it can be particularly hard to not accept the person who is important, and I couldn't feel comfortable thinking that my mom was just angry or that her opinion was unfair, and I had to adjust to keep the intimacy and the safety.

So there was a rule inside: it is better to speak and behave in such a way that I am not rejected.

An Old Movie on a New Screen

Years went by, and instead of my mom, I had an adult audience in front of me, but inside, people could get their role.

And then the image of a strong, meaningful person was carried to the public, who would now judge me and decide if I had the right to speak, and I felt like a child again, who needed to earn acceptance.

The same script could start playing when I published a post, received a comment, or met people at a networking event. I expected rejection even when the other person might simply disagree.

I've worked through this reaction in public speaking, but I still find a similar mechanism in dating women, which is that I'm expected to

be rejected, and this is a topic that I continue to explore and explore.

The old movie is an image, and it helps you see that today's people don't literally become mothers of the past, but that old expectations can be transferred to a new situation.

How the Old Alarm Gets Triggered

I explain this process in a simple sequence.

First, a signal comes in, a person sees, hears, feels, or imagines something, such as seeing an audience or hearing an unexpected question.

Then the situation is quickly assessed through past experience: is it familiar and how did it end before?

If being visible was once associated with shame and rejection, a presentation today can still feel dangerous.

Then the emotional and bodily reaction follows: anxiety, tension, sweaty palms, stiffness, and a trembling voice.

Then comes the thought and desire to avoid the situation:

> *"Let's not go."*
>
> *"Let's do another one."*
>
> *"We have to prepare."*

So it turns out a chain:

Signal → Evaluation through past experience → Experience → Body reaction → Action or avoidance.

This is my working model, which helps explain what's happening in simple terms, and it doesn't describe the diversity of the mental

work, and it doesn't mean that any unpleasant emotion always speaks of danger.

A Real Threat or an Old Reaction?

If a person is attacked by an aggressive dog or physically threatened, the danger is right now, and fear helps mobilize and defend.

Another thing is a hall where people are waiting for performances, and the body reacts as if life is in danger.

Criticism can be unpleasant. Sometimes it has real consequences, like bullying, harassment, or job or reputational threats, so you can't think of any non-physical threat as a fiction.

But the disapproval of a few people doesn't mean that the whole world has rejected a person. If twenty people didn't like the talk, that's twenty people's opinion. Some of you will do well, others won't.

In a normal situation, criticism does not deprive an adult of the opportunity to live, take care of himself, communicate and look for people who are close to his gaze.

It's useful to ask yourself:

What exactly is going on right now?

What consequences do I expect?

How likely are they?

What can I do if they really do come?

Do I suddenly feel like a child again in front of an important adult?

This test helps to distinguish the real threat today from the old scenario.

What Changed When I Found Inner Grounding

Now, when I'm in public speaking, the old reaction is usually not going to work, and I go out and I feel calm and confident.

I no longer see the opinion of others as the ultimate proof of my own worth, and if someone doesn't like what I'm saying, it's their reaction, and I can check for useful feedback, correct a real mistake, and go ahead with my case.

Sometimes a single anxious thought may slip through, or a little uncomfortable feeling may arise, but there is a state inside that I can return to.

> *"I'm safe."*

I am important, needed and valuable to myself.

> *“Another’s reaction doesn’t define me.”*

I bring that back to my attention and keep talking.

This is my personal result. In another person, change can take a different time, it doesn't have to make the person insensitive, it means to me that a random failure or someone else's assessment no longer takes me out of the adult position for a long time.

What to Do When the Alarm Goes Off

If you notice tension, do not rush to suppress it or scold yourself for weakness.

Try walking a few steps.

Notice the Sensation

Where is it in the body? Chests tightened, stomach strained, palms sweated, voices quieter?

You don't have to get rid of it right away. First, just admit, "Yes, I'm not comfortable right now."

Ask What the Worst Outcome Would Be

> *"What do I expect to happen now?"*

Possible answers:

> *"I'm going to be criticized."*
>
> *"I'm rejected."*
>
> *"Everyone will know I'm stupid."*

Listen to the Inner Voice

If you hear “You’re bad,” “You can’t do anything,” or “Don’t be ashamed,” ask:

> *"Whose voice does that remind me of?"*

The answer may not come immediately. Do not invent a childhood story simply because you think there should be one. Rely on what you genuinely remember.

Separate the Thought from Yourself

You could say:

> *"Yes, I have this thought and this feeling, but they're not my whole personality."*
>
> *"I am not someone else's opinion of me."*

I can remain important and valuable to myself.

Check What Is Actually Happening

Look at the people in front of you. Are they really attacking, humiliating, or threatening? Or are they just listening, and the danger is in the scenario that you'd expect?

Choose Your Next Step

Continue. Say, calmly, "I need a few seconds to think," admit that you don't know the answer right now, go back to the slide.

Adult position does not require you to know everything and never get lost.

When I stop fighting my thoughts and feelings, the tension can gradually decrease, and then it is easier for me to continue acting based not on fear of evaluation, but on my own desire and self-worth.

If observing feelings causes a difficult memory or condition that is difficult to cope with on your own, it is best to work with a psychologist or other suitable specialist.

The old alarm system used to try to protect it, but today it can be checked.

Is there a real danger in front of you, or is there an old movie going on again?

Chapter 6. Why “Just Face Your Fear” Does Not Always Work

There were a few minutes left before the exit.

I felt at ease. The lyrics were rehearsed, and during the training, everything was easy, and we learned oratory in a small group of four people we knew, and we spoke to each other many times.

I thought, "Why don't you speak to ten people? I'm ready."

But it was necessary to go to an unfamiliar audience, as the state changed dramatically.

I began forgetting the words. My voice grew quieter. My movements lost their freedom and my posture lost its confidence. Anxiety rose inside me; my hands shook and my palms sweated.

Two minutes ago, I was calm, and now my body was acting like it wasn't the graduation performance that was coming, but it was a serious danger.

I did, and the formal advice of "go to fear" was done.

I'm not freer inside.

When the Test Finally Ends

After the performance, I felt relieved: it was finally over.

I did not feel the satisfaction of taking a meaningful step. I felt the relief of someone who had survived an unpleasant ordeal and was finally allowed to leave.

I knew I had done half the work I could, and I could speak easily in rehearsals, and fear of strangers prevented me from using my training fully.

Along with relief came disappointment:

> *“I’ve been preparing so much and it didn’t work out again.”*

I felt ashamed in front of the coach. She had seen my successful rehearsals and seemed to expect a strong performance, while I felt that I had let her down.

The next thought was familiar: we need to find some more tools, we need to put the voice down, we need to polish the movements, we need to learn the text even more reliably.

So the endless race for tech could go on, and after a bad talk, I didn't ask why a familiar audience felt safe, or a stranger was a big alarm, and I decided I wasn't prepared enough.

Did you do that? Did you take a terrible step, but instead of being confident, you were relieved that it was over?

Skill and Inner Reaction Are Not the Same Thing

Oratory coaches often advise practicing more, going out to the audience more often, and making new attempts.

This advice makes sense. Speaking in public is about specific skills.

speak clearly;

control the volume and pace of the voice;

keep a stable stand;

use appropriate gestures;

Move freely through the stage;

to build a clear structure of speech;

interact with the audience.

These things really develop through training.

The same principle applies to other forms of self-expression. Video requires filming and editing skills. A post requires the ability to structure a text and communicate an idea.

But you can talk well in rehearsals, know the structure of the performance and still squeeze in front of strangers.

It's not just a matter of technology.

The person knows what to do, but the intense tension prevents the use of knowledge: the body becomes constrained, the voice changes, and the rehearsed text disappears.

In my experience, professional training and inner working are different things, one that helps you learn how to speak, and the other that helps you understand why you perceive your performance as a threat.

When Repeated Practice Helps

I distinguish between two levels of fear. It's my working model, not a universal law for every person.

The first level is about doing something. Let's say the person did something wrong. They weren't humiliated or rejected. They just saw that they didn't have enough practice.

Then new attempts can help. The person prepares better, goes back to the audience, gets experience and gradually learns that the skill is developing, and the mistake is not a disaster.

The second level is about self-esteem, and the mistake is not "I can't yet" but:

> *"I'm bad."*
>
> *"I'm stupid."*

"I'm weak."

"Nobody wants me."

"I'm rejected."

In that case, speaking is no longer only practice for a skill. It touches an older experience of shame and rejection.

Repeated safe experiences can also gradually change that response, but an order to "don't think and do" to a person may not be enough, and it's important to see why a single mistake turns internally into a sentence for the whole person.

A Small Step Is an Experiment

Should we give up the practice altogether?

A small step helps to check the dynamics:

write a short post;

record a five-second video;

to make one point;

Speak to a small group;

Tell someone about your work.

After that, it is worth looking not only at the fact of execution, but also at the next attempt.

Has it gotten a little easier? Has it gotten a little less tense? Has it got more freedom?

If the next step is taken more calmly, the practice can be continued gradually.

If the fear remains as intense, if it gets worse, if every attempt requires a huge amount of energy, then one exercise may not be

enough, then you need to deal with the internal cause of the reaction in parallel.

Stepping up is a step that develops when it gives you new experiences and a little bit of freedom, and if every action is experienced as a new confirmation of your own failure, the pressure on yourself can only increase shame and frustration.

What to Look for Beneath the Fear

In the “inner grounding” method, I start with a specific situation.

The person presents a performance, posting or recording of a video and notices where discomfort appears in the body.

Then he asks himself a question:

> *"What's the worst thing that can happen?"*

For example:

> *"I'll be ridiculed."*
>
> *"The listeners will leave."*
>
> *“There will be negative comments under the post.”*
>
> *“People will say I’m publishing nonsense.”*

Next question:

> *“If that happens, how will I feel?”*

The answers may relate to different aspects of self-perception:

> *"I'm stupid, I don't understand anything."*
>
> *“I am weak, small, helpless.”*

I am rejected, unwanted, and abandoned.

And then we can ask:

When was the first time I felt like this?

If a real memory appears, it is important to see what happened, whose words the person took for the truth about himself, and what danger he expected.

The challenge is not to force fear away, but to separate the past from the present and to reclaim the adult position.

> *"I can defend myself now."*
>
> *"I can choose my surroundings."*
>
> *“Another’s disapproval does not determine my worth.”*
>
> *“A mistake in speaking doesn’t make me a bad person.”*

After internal work, you can take a small, real step again and check if the reaction has changed.

If memories cause a severe condition, loss of control, or experiences that are difficult to manage on your own, it is safer to do this work with a psychologist or other suitable professional.

How I Speak in Public Now

One of my more recent talks took place at a networking event. I had to introduce myself and explain what I did.

Without any special preparation, I said that I was a psychologist and crisis psychologist and told the group about my project.

I spoke calmly, without waiting for praise or trying to guess what other people were thinking. I even enjoyed naming my profession openly—without grandiosity and without needing to prove anything.

My body remained relaxed. My palms did not sweat, my hands did not shake, and my voice sounded free.

Even if I had stuttered, it wouldn't have been a failure. I could have corrected and continued.

Now I'm taking it easier:

I am a normal human being, not a robot.

> *"I have the right to be wrong."*
>
> *“I can forget something and still be valuable to myself.”*

In the past, a situation was what defined my attitude toward myself, and if I did not perform well, then I was bad.

Now I don't define myself through a situation; I determine how to treat it and what to do next.

This is my personal result. The other person may have different depth of response, help and speed of change.

Not a Feat, but a New Experience

Fear is not always a bad advice, and sometimes you really don't have enough practice, and trying again gives you a useful experience.

The problem begins when this advice is used instead of understanding the cause.

If a person comes out of intense tension every time, and after a performance feels only shame, relief and the desire to disappear, he does not need to put more pressure on himself.

We can stop and ask:

Am I missing a specific skill or am I already doing it in rehearsal?

Does the next attempt get easier or does the fear stay the same?

Am I afraid of making a mistake—or of feeling bad, unwanted, or unworthy?

What past experience reminds me of today’s situation?

What kind of support is needed now: training, psychological work or a combination of them?

I can't promise you that two or three meetings will be enough for anyone, that sometimes change really comes quickly, sometimes it takes longer, and that it's more honest to look at real life change than a beautiful promise.

The goal is not to prepare for years, but it's not to prove strength by breaking yourself through your knee every time.

Good practice gradually brings back more freedom, and the person doesn't just stand up to the performance, they get the opportunity to be alive.

Chapter 7. The Movie in My Head

It was happening on networking.

I had to stand up in front of people, introduce myself and tell people about myself: who I am, what I do, what project I am working on.

As I talked, I looked at the faces of the audience, and I wanted to see the approval and make sure everything was going well, but at the same time I was looking for signs of ridicule.

Someone was talking to a neighbor, someone was looking at the booklet and they were smiling, and I was like,

> *"They're laughing at me."*

It was like the sound of what these people didn't say out loud:

> *"Which is he a psychologist?"*
>
> *"What kind of specialist is he?"*
>
> *"I think I've learned something and now I'm going to speak."*

I hadn't finished talking about myself, and in my head, the audience had already sentenced me, and then my body would strain, my voice would change, and I would start to get lost and lose my calm.

The person just looked away, frowned, or chuckled, and you've already decided that they're thinking about you.

When There Is No Fact Yet, but the Story Is Already There

And then I realized that those people were laughing at something of their own, they weren't talking to me, they weren't interrupting me, they weren't commenting on my talk, they were just reading booklets, talking to each other, and they were smiling.

If you separate the facts from my interpretation, you get the following.

Fact: Two people were talking and laughing.

My story: They laugh at me and think I'm a bad specialist.

There was no confirmation, but automatic thought triggered a real reaction: anxiety, tension, and the desire to finish the talk as soon as possible.

Something interesting happens here. Other people may not be thinking about me at all, yet I am already living inside the negative opinion I imagine they hold. I invent their words, believe them, and then contract in response to my own invention.

So I made a movie about myself.

Why Someone Else’s Laughter Feels Like It Is About You

I started looking deeper and remembering why someone else's laughter hurt me so much.

I was about six years old. I loved the song "Earth in the window." One day my mother asked me to sing. I sang, and she started laughing.

I cannot know exactly what she felt or what her laughter meant. Perhaps her reaction was not about me at all. But to the little boy I was, it felt as if she were laughing not with me, but at me—at my singing, my appearance, and my attempt to express myself.

Inside, it could sound something like this:

> *"You're small and stupid."*

When a child is laughed at by a stranger, it's unpleasant, and when that's how the mother's reaction, on which love, care and safety depend, is perceived, the experience can be much stronger.

I felt ashamed. I learned that expressing myself, opening up, doing something from the heart, or looking foolish could be dangerous.

I am not claiming that this single episode was the only cause of my fear. But it helps me understand the connection. At the networking event, unfamiliar adults sat in front of me, while my inner reaction resembled that of the little boy who sang his favorite song and decided people were laughing at him.

The present has changed, but the old meaning has remained:

> *“If someone is laughing, there’s something wrong with me.”*

How the Mind Fills in the Blanks

First impressions are very quick. We notice the look, the facial expression, the voice, the gait, the clothes, the movements and the behavior of the person, and everything we see is compared to the past experience.

Does it remind me of someone I know, was it safe for me to be around people like me, could I trust or should I be more vigilant?

So first assumptions come about. They're sometimes useful, but they're still assumptions, not accurate knowledge about a person.

For example, I might look at a woman I don't know and think,

> *"She must have a complicated character."*

Another person looks at her and says,

> *“What a nice, gentle and friendly girl.”*

The woman is one, and the experiences are different, and everyone has seen not only her, but also their own experiences: familiar faces, past relationships, expectations, fears and hopes.

It happens to me, too. The other person looks at me, but gives meaning to what he sees in his life. One person will find my honesty, the other will see my harshness. One person will see confidence, the other will see self-confidence. The third person will give me no meaning at all.

So the other person's opinion can't just speak about me, it's always the experience of the observer.

It doesn't mean that any feedback should be rejected. Sometimes people notice things that I don't see, and you can test and use specific and respectful feedback, but the first facial expression, one laugh, or even someone's assessment, is not the whole truth about me.

Who Am I When Everyone Sees Me Differently?

I used to want to be admired, and I wanted to do something big and hear,

> *"You're so cool."*

Imagine that one person sees me as almost enlightened and admires every word I say, another rejects or even hates me, and a third barely notices me and forgets me a minute later.

Who am I then: a hero, a villain, or an empty place?

If you rely on other people's judgments, you don't have a sustainable response, you have to change every minute with the expressions of the people around you, you've got praise, I'm valuable, you've got criticism, something's wrong with me, you haven't noticed, I'm not there.

You can live life inside other people’s heads and gradually lose contact with yourself.

For me, the inner grounding is deeper than the individual assessments of others and my own self-images, and I see it as an inner right to exist, to be myself, and to feel valued without being constantly tested by others.

This is my personal understanding and philosophical image, not the scientific statement that man is born with a ready-made conception of himself.

Now inside, I can say:

> *"I matter."*
>
> *"I'm valuable."*
>
> *"I'm free."*
>
> *“I can support myself.”*

It doesn't make me perfect, and it doesn't mean I'm always right, it just doesn't have to determine my worth anymore.

How to Check the Movie in Your Head

When the thought “They laugh at me” or “They think I’m stupid” comes up, I can stop and check instead of taking it as fact.

Here are some of the questions I have in common with Byron Katie’s self-exploration practice, The Work:

Is that true?

Can I absolutely know that this is true?

How do I react and what happens to me when I believe in this idea?

Who or what would I be without that thought?

Take my networking situation.

> *"They're laughing at me."*

Is that true? Maybe. But maybe something else: They're discussing a booklet, remembering their story, or not listening to me at all at that moment.

Can I know for sure that this is true? No. They didn't tell me that.

What happens when I believe in my own thought? I strain, I get confused, I lose contact with what I wanted to communicate, and I start to perform worse.

What would I be without that thought? I would keep talking, stay in touch with myself and the audience, and if people were really in the way, I could clarify the situation or get their attention back without turning one laugh into an assessment of my whole personality.

It is useful to ask yourself about another:

What do I see and hear now, really?

What have I already assumed about the other person?

Whose familiar voice is in my head?

What am I to myself if I stop guessing someone else’s assessment for a minute?

Do I like what I'm doing?

Can I enjoy the process even if the result is not perfect?

The point is not to convince yourself, "Everybody loves me, for sure," but to read other people's thoughts with a plus sign.

Honestly,

> *"I don't know what they think, but I know why I came here and what I want to say."*

Win Your Own Heart First

You can't please everyone and everyone will.

No matter how carefully you choose your words, some people will find your style too soft and others too direct. Some will support your idea, some will pass by, and some will view it through the lens of their own painful experience.

If you try to manage all these reactions, you will no longer have the strength to live.

So first, it's important to win your heart, to hear yourself, to accept yourself, and to feel valued, not just in moments of success.

And then emerge from this state – not for the sake of deserved approval, but out of self-love, inner fulfillment and the desire to share what is important to you.

Some people won't like the real you, but some people will like you.

The main thing is that in an attempt to please everyone you do not lose the person with whom you live your whole life: yourself.

Four questions are given on the official description of Byron Katie's self-exploration practice, The Work: thework.com (https://thework.com/instruction-the-work-byron-katie/).

Part III: The inner grounding Method

Chapter 8. What Inner Grounding Is

I used to find it hard to say calmly in front of people:

> *"I'm a psychologist. I work with crisis conditions."*

It seemed like a normal idea, a few words about myself and my work, but when I started talking about how things were changing inside.

My throat tightened. My voice grew quieter, my hands tensed and began to shake, and my palms sweated. At the same time, the thoughts began:

> *"What kind of psychologist are you?"*

I had not yet seen the audience's real response, but I had already imagined them doubting me and dismissing everything I said.

You didn't just have to talk about yourself, you had to fight your own body, control your voice, and prove your right to be in front of people.

After working with the inner grounding, I felt for the first time that I could introduce myself differently: quietly name my profession and talk about the project - without squeezing my throat and waiting for someone to expose me now.

Talking to the audience began to resemble a normal conversation with a friend.

I didn't become the perfect speaker, and I didn't get a guarantee that every talk would go without a single mistake, but what changed was that I didn't have to prove my right to be myself anymore.

Being There for Yourself

When a person has an inner grounding, he feels his own value, need and importance for himself.

He doesn’t have to constantly look outside for confirmation:

> *"Tell me I'm good."*
>
> *"Prove you need me."*
>
> *“Show me that I have the right to do this.”*

It doesn't mean that he doesn't need a relationship or a support or an acknowledgement at all; we feel good when we're understood, loved and valued, but approval is no longer the only basis on which self-esteem is based.

A person may want to perform well, engage an audience, and get positive feedback, but the outcome of a talk doesn't define who he is.

If it went well, he's happy, if he made a mistake, he analyzes it and he corrects it, and he stays fine inside.

The internal position may sound like this:

> *"This performance didn't go the way I wanted it to go, but that doesn't mean there's something wrong with me."*

This is one of the central differences. Without inner grounding, a person judges themselves through every situation: If I succeeded, I am good. If I failed, I am bad, stupid, and unworthy.

With inner grounding, a person approaches the situation from a sense of their own worth. The result can be improved, while the right to respect oneself does not have to be earned all over again.

How a Child Learns to See Himself Through Other People’s Eyes

So imagine a normal scene, a child riding with his mother on public transport, laughing, talking loudly, pampering and showing himself freely.

Mommy's tense:

"Don't do that."

"Don't embarrass me."

"Behave yourself."

She may be afraid of being judged or ashamed, and an adult may assume that. A child may not.

He doesn’t think, “Mummy is having a hard time keeping the attention of others right now, and her reaction is to her own experience.”

He can hear something else:

"I'm so bad."

"I'm embarrassing my mom."

When I express myself, she rejects me.

For the child, the mother's attitude is about care and safety, so her discontent may not be perceived as a simple plea to speak quietly, but as a threat of rejection:

“If I remain as I am, she will not need me.”

The child begins to adapt: he tries to be easy to manage, stays quiet, avoids attention, stops singing and playing around, and gradually suppresses his natural self-expression in order to preserve the love of an important adult.

It's not that children don't need boundaries, it's really worth speaking quietly in a public place, but there's a difference between the two messages.

> *"You're talking too loud now. Keep it down."*

And:

> *"You're bad and you're embarrassing me."*

In the first case, the adult helps to correct the behavior, in the second case, the child may decide that the problem is not the volume, but the child himself.

As an adult, he continues to look for someone who will confirm his right to be himself, only instead of his mother, he now has an audience, a boss, followers, a partner or random people.

What happened to you? Did you get told what action to change, or did you feel that you were wrong?

Correcting a Mistake Without Destroying Yourself

The inner grounding is especially visible after an error.

Suppose a person spoke to an audience, got confused about the numbers, or couldn’t answer a question.

Without an inner backing, a mistake quickly becomes a sentence:

> *"I'm stupid."*
>
> *"I ruined it."*
>
> *"I lost my face."*
>
> *"No one else will come to me."*

One mistake becomes a threat to the whole reputation, and the person doesn't think about what can be fixed, he tries to cope with the feeling of his own failure.

With an inner grounding, the reaction is different:

> *"Yes, I made a mistake here. I can admit it, fix it, and take it into account next time, but my mistake doesn't mean I'm a mistake myself."*

The human being remembers that he's not a robot, and he doesn't have to do everything perfectly, he can listen to feedback, he can apologize, he can make amends, he can reconsider his decision, and he can still not humiliate himself from the inside.

For me, the difference between the two states is important:

I made a mistake and I am responsible for it.

I am a bad person and therefore I do not deserve to be treated normally.

The first leaves the strength to act. The second often leads to shame, self-punishment and the desire to hide.

Some people have come to believe that without a lot of guilt, you can't get better, especially if you were raised with the phrase "you're bad," "you embarrassed us," or "you made me feel ashamed."

I think of it differently, because to be responsible for what you do, you don't have to destroy your own value, you can feel uncomfortable, you can see the consequences, and you can decide to do something different.

So the inner grounding is not indifference, not selfishness, not permission to do anything, but the ability to stay on your side without giving up responsibility and respect for others.

How Inner Grounding Feels in the Body

Before the internal work, my body was preparing for danger during performances.

My arms and legs tensed. I felt stiffness, heaviness, trembling, and sweating. My voice grew weaker, as if it too had lost its support.

Most of the attention was not focused on the meaning of the speech, but on the internal check:

> *"How do I look?"*
>
> *"What will they think of me?"*
>
> *"Am I performing well?"*

My state in situations like this has changed. My feet remain firmly on the floor, my arms move more freely, and my voice sounds calm and strong enough. I no longer need to monitor the listeners' faces every second.

I can focus on what I want to say and enjoy the process.

For me, the inner grounding of the body is calmness, stability and freedom of movement, and I don't freeze waiting for an assessment, but I stay in touch with myself and my work.

But the support does not mean that a person will never be hurt again.

A trigger can cause a disturbing thought, an unpleasant feeling, or a little tension, the difference being that it doesn't necessarily take the whole person over.

The Ocean Beneath the Storm

I think of the inner grounding as the ocean.

The waves rise, the thoughts, the feelings move a little deeper, and a hurricane can come out of the top.

But deep down, it's quiet and quiet, so quiet that even a grain of sand can't move at the bottom.

So it's inside of us, and thoughts and feelings don't have to disappear forever, but underneath, there's a deep knowledge.

> *"I'm all right."*
>
> *"I remain valuable to myself."*
>
> *“I can stand this reaction and keep acting.”*

The challenge is not to become insensitive; it is important that a single wave no longer destroys the entire inner core.

Tar Beneath a Layer of Honey

The inner grounding is easily confused with autosuggestion.

The man says,

> *"I'm the best."*
>
> *"I'm confident."*
>
> *"I don't care what people think of me."*

But inside, he continues to feel inadequate and wait for someone else’s approval.

I think of it this way: you have tar inside, you put honey on top of it, but it doesn't make tar honey. It's only temporarily covered with a sweet layer.

A new trigger comes in -- criticism, someone else's laugh, or the need to speak -- and the old reaction rises again, the throat shrinks,

the voice changes, the palms sweat, the body fires before the person can repeat the right phrase.

Affirmations can temporarily support or remind you of a position you've chosen, but in my experience, they don't always change an old automatic response when it involves a deep experience of rejection.

My inner work was to find the experiences that were involved in this reaction, to rethink it, to separate the past from the present, to painful memories that cause a difficult state or loss of control, it is safer to return with the right specialist.

After that work, I didn't have to constantly convince myself that I was valuable and confident, but I started to feel it more calmly inside.

That's how I distinguish between a mask of confidence and a foothold.

With a mask, the person tries to look calm, controls every movement and repeats the right words, but inside, he keeps waiting for the evaluation.

With an inner grounding, he doesn't have to prove confidence to others or to himself; he can just be himself and act.

It Is Not the Scene Itself

Sometimes changes are not only in the situation with which the person started.

For example, he dealt with his fear of public speaking, and then noticed that it became easier for him to talk about his rights at work and ask for a raise.

Or someone tries to walk without a queue, and he calmly says:

"Sorry, but there's a line here."

No attack, no long excuses, no trembling in his voice.

This can happen when different situations have been linked to the same reason, the expectation of judgment or rejection, but it's not the promise of complete calm in all areas of life forever, but each person has his or her own stories, reactions and pace of change.

For me, the real inner strength is not recognized by the loud words about one's own strength, but by the calm and free action.

You can make mistakes and make amends.

You can hear someone else's opinion and decide if this feedback is right for you.

You can defend your borders without attacking.

You can express yourself without turning every reaction from another person into a verdict about who you are.

And you don't have to constantly earn the right to be valuable, you stay on your side, and you go from there to life.

What do you think you are doing today, or what do you think you are doing?

Chapter 9. Mapping Your Fear

I was once at a fashion show in Izhevsk, at the People's Friendship House, representing the Tidery brand, and I had to walk twice with a group of kids on the runway, show them costumes and get in certain positions.

The audience gathered people from the fashion sector: fashion designers, specialists, those who look at clothes and the show itself with a professional look.

And as I was standing backstage, everything was calm, and I was looking out into the room and I was thinking, "What's the big deal? Let's go out and walk and come back."

But I stepped on the podium, like the alarm went off inside.

My body shrank. My arms and legs tightened, my legs shivered, my chest got a nasty lump, my face started burning, and maybe the audience didn't notice it very much, but I was shaking inside.

At the same time, thoughts emerged:

"I don't look like that somehow."

"I'm not going right."

“Everyone will notice that something is wrong with me.”

“I’ll be laughed at, discussed, filmed and put on the Internet.”

I wanted to move smoothly and freely, just as we had rehearsed. But the harder I tried to walk correctly, the more tense I became. My movements grew stiff and abrupt. I stopped thinking about the suit or how to present it and thought only about how I looked.

"Do you see I'm afraid?"

"How do I look now?"

"When is this gonna end?"

How Fear Reinforces Itself

We were a team at the show, and we had to take turns getting out, going all over the place, getting together, taking our seats, and leaving the stage in time.

When your body is tense, even a familiar sequence becomes confusing. You forget where to walk and where to stop. You notice a mistake, become even more frightened, and tense up further.

It turns out to be a vicious circle:

I walked onto the podium and felt my eyes.

I thought, “There’s something wrong with me.”

Fear and shame turned on.

The body became tense, the movements became less free.

The tension made me confused.

The mistakes seemed to confirm the original thought: “I’m really doing everything wrong.”

I wanted only one thing: to get out of there as quickly as possible.

When the performance ended, I was relieved that everything, thank God, could be exhaled.

Then I felt confused. I had been calm backstage. No one was threatening me on the runway. Why had my body reacted as if I were in danger?

This question was the beginning of my discussion.

Shame Was Beneath the Fear

Sometimes we say, "I'm afraid to speak," but the word "fear" is not enough to tell us what's going on.

I was not afraid of the runway itself; it could not harm me. I was afraid that people would see something wrong with me.

Behind the thought of the wrong gait was a deeper feeling:

> *"I'm funny."*
>
> *"I look stupid."*
>
> *"There's something wrong with me."*

And that's where shame joined in, and fear pushed me to go to safety, and shame demanded that I be corrected so that people would not notice my "wrongness."

So it's important to ask ourselves, not just, "What am I afraid of?" There's another question.

> *“How do I feel when this happens?”*

Stupid? Small? Weak? Ridiculous? Unwanted? Rejected?

The answer often shows that people don't just defend themselves against a bad performance, they don't just try to be the person they once feared to be in the eyes of the people who matter.

Another Scene

When I started looking for a place where I had experienced a similar condition, I remembered the New Year’s Eve morning in kindergarten.

I was wearing short shorts, a shirt and a tie that I didn't like, and we didn't have any other clothes, because we didn't have enough, and I was embarrassed to go out like that.

I had to read a poem. I was afraid to forget the words, I was afraid that children and adults would laugh. I saw my mother's eyes and I felt her displeasure during the talk. I really forgot the poem.

A simple children's story could be embedded inside:

> *"I ruined it again."*
>
> *"I embarrassed my mom."*
>
> *"When I express myself, people will reject me."*

I can't absolutely reconstruct every thought of my little self, but the feeling on the runway was very similar: shame at appearance, anticipation of ridicule, fear of making mistakes, and the feeling that someone important would be unhappy with me right now.

In the present, I had designers and audiences, but the internal reaction was not just for them, but it was an old experience in which performance was already associated with shame and the threat of rejection.

It doesn't mean that there's a childhood trauma behind every excitement, and sometimes people really lack experience or training, but if the situation is objectively safe, and the reaction is too strong and repeats itself over and over again, it's worth looking at whether the story is an older story inside.

What Is a Fear Map?

The fear map is not for a long time to dig into yourself and look for a beautiful psychological explanation, it helps you see a particular chain that usually works in a few seconds.

Discuss one episode, not fear "at all."

Situation

What happened right before the reaction?

I stepped out from backstage onto the runway and saw people watching me.

Body

Where did the discomfort come from?

My arms and legs tensed, I began to tremble, my chest tightened, and my face grew hot.

Sometimes it is easier to start with the body because the thought has time to slip very quickly, and the bodily reaction remains noticeable.

Automatic Thoughts

What did you say to yourself at that moment?

> *"I don't look right."*
>
> *"I'm going to be laughed at."*
>
> *"Everybody will notice my fear."*

Write down your thoughts as they are. Don't make them intelligent or beautiful right away.

Feelings

Was it fear, shame, guilt, sadness, loneliness or another condition?

My story was about fear and shame.

How You See Yourself

How did you feel?

Not "what I did wrong," but "what I am now."

> *"I'm funny."*
>
> *"I'm stupid."*

"I don't look like that."

The Worst-Case Scenario

What do you think will happen next?

People will laugh? They will judge? They will reject? They will think you're incapable of anything? What will that mean to you personally?

It is important not to intimidate yourself, but to see the end point of the internal scenario.

The Protective Reaction and Its Consequences

What do you want to do?

To walk away, to shut up, to look away, to control everything, to refuse the next performance?

And how did it end? Did it get easier? What happened later?

Leaving the stage brought relief, which made the pattern clear: the danger seemed to be over. But if you escape every time, the mind receives the same confirmation again: “Good thing we left. It really was dangerous.”

Earlier Experiences That Felt the Same

When did you feel the same way before?

You don't have to remember your childhood right away, you don't have to squeeze out a memory, sometimes you get a connection later, and sometimes you find that your current fear isn't about a distant past, it's about a recent failure.

For me, this connection was a morning in kindergarten.

Do Not Fight the Alarm

When the map is seen, one can see the important thing: thought is not an event, and feeling is not proof of danger.

I could think, "Everybody's going to see something wrong with me now," but it was a thought, not an established fact.

I could feel a lot of shame, but the shame itself didn't prove that I really looked ridiculous or that the audience was going to reject me.

It helped me not to argue with the reaction and not to tell myself to calm down right away, and the more I tried to hide the fear, the more I paid attention to it.

Instead of fighting, you can try to say to yourself:

> *“Yes, I’m scared and ashamed right now.”*
>
> *"I feel tension in my body."*
>
> *“There was an old story in my head that there was something wrong with me.”*
>
> *"But now I'm an adult and I'm in the present. Other people's opinions may be unpleasant, but they don't threaten my life."*

It's not a magic phrase that says fear has to go away, but it's a different meaning: stop accepting the automatic response as the whole of reality and take back the ability to choose action.

Supporting Your Younger Self

Another practice is especially meaningful to me. In my mind, I picture the younger version of myself who felt ashamed and frightened at that kindergarten performance. I imagine holding him and saying:

> *"You're safe. Don't be afraid, I'm with you. I'm accepting you. I'm not leaving you."*

It's not about pretending that the past didn't exist, but I admit that I really didn't have enough support, I didn't know how to defend myself, and I was too dependent on the attitude of adults.

But right now, there's an adult me next to that kid.

I can remind myself:

> *"I've grown up. I can take care of myself. I'm valuable, needed and important to myself."*

As a child, the discontent of a close adult could feel like a threat to all security, and now someone else's disapproval does not make me a helpless child, it can hurt, but I can stand it, decide whether this feedback is useful for me, and go on living.

If painful memories cause too much reaction, loss of control, or a condition that is difficult to manage on your own, it is best to approach such work with the right specialist.

Not Euphoria, but Calm

How do you know if your inner workings are starting to help?

For me, the main sign is not a loud confidence and not a feeling that I am not afraid of anything.

The usual calm comes.

Thoughts become quieter. My body relaxes. I have a lightness and a sense of inner integrity, and I don't have to prove to myself that I'm brave, or go forward in a constant struggle with myself.

I'm just doing what I wanted to do:

I go out to people;

talk about myself;

I'm recording a video.

I'm posting.

There may be some excitement, but it doesn't necessarily govern the whole body and every decision.

And that's the meaning of the fear map, which doesn't cancel out feelings, but it helps you to stop being held hostage to them, to see what's turned on, where it's familiar, and what action I'm taking now.

And if you look at your latest fear situation from this map, what is the phrase that comes to the center: “I’m going to be wrong” or “something’s wrong with me?”

Chapter 10. Returning to Your Adult Self

When I was in the hiring industry, I was sometimes criticized by the management for my mistakes, and I was working in situations where I might not understand something, or I might do something wrong, or I might ask for help to figure it out.

The mistake wasn't always serious, but my inner reaction was completely out of step with the scale of the mistake.

When the boss started to tell me how stupid and small and guilty I felt, I blushed and couldn't explain what had happened, as if the boss was not a grown man, but a child being scolded.

My body was becoming "little," too, and I would hunch, lower my head, my shoulders would roll in, and I would clench, I would become invisible, I would leave, so I wouldn't feel shame or guilt.

Inside, it sounded:

> *"Me again."*
>
> *"I'm not getting anywhere."*
>
> *"I'm stupid."*
>
> *"Everyone understands, and I don't understand."*
>
> *"I ruined it again."*

I didn't think about how to fix a particular mistake, but it was a question that shifted from action to personality, not "I haven't figured out the problem yet," but "something's wrong with me."

When a Boss Becomes an Authority Figure

I heard similar words as a child.

In first grade, I was just learning to write prescriptions, and it wasn't all right the first time, and there were poems that I found hard to remember.

My mom and grandma compared me to others.

> *“Everyone does it, and you don’t.”*

> *“All people are like people, and you are like....”*

I was in first grade and you can’t.

To an adult, this may look like an attempt to get the child to do their best, but the child doesn't always hear, "You're having a hard time with this task."

I heard another thing:

> *“Everyone is normal and I’m wrong.”*

> *"I'm stupid."*

> *“The problem is not the task, it is me.”*

The feeling was so painful that one thought rose inside me: “I am some kind of freak.”

As an adult, I continued to learn the same tone of criticism of leadership, and the boss talked about the job, and inside the old sentence was raised: "Everybody does it, and you're not like that."

I felt like a child standing before an important adult on whom my safety depended.

Then and Now

It is important to separate the past from the present.

As a child, I was really dependent on adults for food, clothing, shelter, care and security, and I couldn't stop talking, change my family, or decide that someone else's assessment didn't fit me.

So the discontent of a mother or a grandmother could not feel like a mere criticism, but could mean, for a young child,

> *“If I don’t fit them, they won’t love me.”*
>
> *“If I am rejected, I will be left alone.”*

The reality at work is different.

Yes, relationships with a boss affect income, career and living conditions, and getting fired can be a real challenge, but my life is no longer dependent on one person, as a child's life depends on a parent.

I can explain my position, ask for specifics, seek help, correct a mistake, mark a boundary, apply higher or find another job.

I had a choice that I didn’t have when I was a kid.

To be back in the adult position for me means to see the difference not only with my head, but also inside.

> *"I'm already grown."*
>
> *"I can take care of myself."*
>
> *“Another’s discontent is unpleasant, but it does not define who I am.”*

A Mistake Does Not Define You

Adult position does not mean to think that you are always right and not to take comments.

I can be wrong. I may not know. In one area I'm stronger, in another I'm weaker. Some tasks are quick, others require training, time or help.

I am not a robot, I am not a wizard, and I don’t have to be perfect everywhere.

The question is what the criticism is about.

If it's about my act, skill or outcome, I can look at the facts:

What exactly happened?

What was the result expected?

What am I really responsible for?

What can be fixed?

What kind of help or information do I need?

Useful feedback helps you see the action and change it, and humiliation hits the personality and often goes unspecific: "You're stupid," "You're not capable of anything," "You're always wrong."

I can take the first part and not take the second.

> *"Yes, I made a mistake here. I'll correct it. But this situation doesn't prove that I'm bad or incapable."*

My actions have consequences, and they have to be held accountable, but one action does not determine my identity and my worth.

How I Return to the Present

When the old reaction is triggered, I first shift my attention within.

I'm not trying to immediately destroy the disturbing thoughts or make the body relax.

"Now I'm shrunk."

"I'm ashamed."

“I thought I was stupid and I screwed up again.”

It's my thoughts, my feelings, my bodily reactions, and I don't deny them, but I don't let them decide for me who I am.

To me, the inner grounding sounds like this:

"I remain the most valuable, important and necessary person to myself, the answer to the question of who I am is between me and God, the other person's opinion is the other person's idea of me, not the whole truth about me."

Then I return to the present with a few questions:

How old am I now?

Am I a child or an adult now?

Is there an immediate threat to my life and physical safety?

What would really happen if this person was not happy with me?

What options do I have?

If there is no physical threat, verbal criticism is not in itself a threat to my survival; it can be painful, and prolonged humiliation can cause real harm, so adulthood is not about being patient, it's about seeing things soberly and choosing how to defend yourself.

Your Adult Body

Childhood helplessness was felt in the body as a decrease: head down, shoulders in, voice is quieter.

I feel different in my adult life, I spread my shoulders, I feel both legs and support under them, my body becomes calmer and freer, I don't try to be invisible.

I don't have to make a hasty excuse, swallow words or attack back.

I can tell the boss:

> *"I agree, I made a mistake here. Let's solve the problem. I need time to fix it."*

If I don't understand something:

> *"Can you please explain what needs to be done differently: Is there a manual, additional material or a staff member who can give you a hint?"*

If the conversation turns into humiliation:

> *"I'm willing to discuss the error and how to correct it, but please don't go over my personality."*

It's not an excuse or an attack, I acknowledge the fact, offer action and maintain respect for myself.

Quiet Strength

It is easy to confuse an adult response with rebellion.

You can stretch your shoulders, raise your voice, slam the door, and decide that you've finally defended yourself, but you can still have the same wounded child inside that child who's just gone from helplessness to assault.

Anger often protects a sick and vulnerable place, and if criticism makes me feel worthless, I feel like I'm going to hit back with words.

For me, the real power seems calmer.

I may disagree.

I can stop the disrespectful conversation.

I can refuse to accept conditions that are not suitable for me.

I can leave if the relationship doesn't change.

But I'm not doing this to humiliate the other person, I'm doing this out of respect for myself and understanding my boundaries.

Even dismissal doesn't have to be an internal sentence, it can be financially difficult and require new solutions, but it doesn't prove that there's something wrong with me.

I remain on my own side and ask, “What can I do now?”

You Do Not Have to Be Perfect

To return to adulthood is to stop demanding the impossible.

I can make mistakes and correct myself.

I don't know. I can ask.

I can be strong in one and less experienced in the other.

I can accept useful criticism and refuse to accept humiliation.

My value does not absolve me of responsibility; it empowers me to sustain that responsibility without destroying myself from within.

And when a leader, a spectator, or anyone else is unhappy with me, they are not a helpless child, but an adult, with their mistakes, their dignity, their boundaries, and their right to choose what to do.

What do you become when you criticize, an adult who is dealing with the situation, or a young child who is trying to earn the right to be good again?

Chapter 11. Reclaiming the Part of Yourself You Rejected

As a child, I loved to crook, chat, laugh and run.

I could sing songs, repeat what I saw somewhere, say something childish and awkward, I didn't think it was useful, how right I looked or what people would say about me.

In those moments, I felt light, joy and security, as if the world was accepting me and I was okay.

I didn't have to deserve to be myself, I felt needed and valued just because I existed.

And then that freedom started to disappear.

When Being Alive Starts to Feel Shameful

My mother worked hard, so my grandmother often worked with me.

She told me:

> *"Don't embarrass me."*
>
> *"Behave yourself."*
>
> *"Don't be crooked."*
>
> *"It's not proper to behave like that."*

I did what kids do: laugh, talk, pretend, move freely, but I felt like my grandmother was ashamed of me.

My mother would laugh at me sometimes, and I would not see her laugh as warm and kind, but as a mockery of a stupid, awkward child who does things wrong.

She often said,

"Silence is gold."

“The more you keep quiet, the less you look stupid.”

"Keep your head down."

“Be quieter than the water, below the grass.”

The logic was simple: if you talk less, people might think you're smart. If you talk, you swindle, you get attention, you're going to be considered a fool.

Silence became more than a rule of good behavior. It became protection: if you do not speak or draw attention to yourself, you are less likely to be mocked, shamed, or accused of embarrassing your family.

Whose Shame Was It?

Now I ask myself, why was my mom and grandma so ashamed of my normal childhood behavior?

I can't know exactly what was going on inside them, but I assume they were very dependent on someone else's judgment, and maybe they lacked the inner grounding of their own acceptance, self-worth, self-respect, security and freedom.

When a person lacks inner grounding, other people’s reactions become too important. A lively, noisy child may then be seen not as a living child, but as a threat to an adult’s reputation:

"What will they think of me?"

“They think I raised the child badly.”

"I'll be ashamed of people."

In those moments, other people’s judgment may have outweighed their ability to show a child love and acceptance. That does not

necessarily mean that my mother or grandmother never loved me. But their own shame may have overwhelmed that love at the very moment I needed support.

This is the case in many families, where the adult is struggling with his fear of judgment and is trying to change the child quickly to stop feeling shame, and the child concludes that the problem and love must be earned by the right behavior.

How a Compliant Child Is Made

To keep my relationships with important adults, I had to hide my free and joyful self.

It felt dangerous to not live up to expectations, and a child could be cornered, punished, punched, or made clear, "We don't need you like that."

My mother could say very harsh things.

> *"You're just ruining everything."*
>
> *"You're just interfering with my life."*

Threats of rejection were also heard: "I don't want you like that. I'd rather have you in boarding school."

Sometimes the problem was stained or torn clothing. Money was scarce, so damaging something mattered. But a child cannot separate an adult’s financial stress from the adult’s attitude toward him. I heard more than “Your jacket is torn.” I felt, “My very existence is a burden. I ruin everything.”

Then a comfortable child came to the place of a free child.

He talks less.

No argument.

It doesn't attract attention.

He doesn't talk about success.

He tries to guess what he wants to see and deserve good behavior.

The rejected part is not the individual within the human being, but to me it is the image of those qualities, feelings and desires that were once forbidden: spontaneity, joy, voice, the right to be wrong and to be seen.

The Price of Silence in Adulthood

Child protection continued to work when I grew up.

I was afraid to say too much or express my opinion. When people criticized me, I stayed silent and did not defend myself. In front of stronger or more important people, I could cry from helplessness because I once again felt like a weak child.

I found it hard to dance sober, and without alcohol, I hardly ever went on the dance floor, because I felt the eyes of others too much.

I was afraid of public speaking, promoting myself, and selling. When I worked in sales, I felt ashamed to offer a product, speak with customers, or make cold calls.

It was also awkward to talk about my own experiences and achievements, and it was very childish.

> *"No bragging."*
>
> *"Don't yak."*
>
> *“I am the last letter in the alphabet.”*

Even praise I had earned brought shame and guilt. I blushed and minimized what I had done, as if I had no right to believe I had done something well.

In this way, the ban on childish playfulness gradually became a ban on adult self-expression.

Other Experiences

The change started when I met a group of people who didn’t drink alcohol or other substances.

They went to discos, danced, talked about themselves, and shared what they had done in the week, and it was a warm circle.

People were genuinely listening and cheering for each other, and I started to get a new experience.

I tell you about myself, I am not ridiculed.

I dance, I'm not ashamed.

I’m talking about achievements, people can enjoy it with me.

I was still stuck at first, I was dancing tight, I was talking carefully, but it was getting easier.

At one point, I was able to say calmly that I was a psychologist who worked with crisis situations, that I had professional training and a degree, and that I also had extensive business experience. I could name my strengths and results.

I could say bragged, but I didn't feel guilty anymore.

Instead, there was dignity: I have the right to acknowledge what I have done.

Why Reassurance Alone Is Not Enough

The warm circle was important, and it showed that people can react differently than mom and grandma.

But I realized that if my attitude toward myself is completely dependent on others, I need confirmation all the time.

Today someone supports me, so I feel good about myself. Tomorrow someone criticizes me, and I feel unwanted again.

So outside support didn't replace inner work, it was important for me to stop rejecting myself.

Using the Inner Grounding approach, I worked with shame, feeling unwanted, and fear of abandonment. I learned to experience my worth without depending entirely on praise.

Supporting others is still important and enjoyable, and we don't have to become people who don't need anyone, but the approval of others is no longer the only pillar without which everything collapses.

I can accept praise and be happy with it, I can hear criticism and see if it's useful, and in both cases, I can not lose myself.

What Does It Mean to Reclaim This Part of Yourself?

For me, the first step is to admit that I once rejected my little self because his feelings and behavior seemed dangerous.

Now we can think of him in terms of:

> *"You're my part. I see you and I accept you."*

You can relate differently to the thoughts and feelings that arise before you make yourself visible:

> *"These are my thoughts. These are my feelings. These are the old alarms that try to protect me from ridicule and rejection."*

You don't have to chase her away or prove that she's not afraid, you can figure out why she's turned on and say,

> *"Thank you for trying to protect me. I'm an adult now. Those thoughts and feelings are safe for me in and of themselves."*

I imagine a little myself, hug him and remind him:

> *"You don't have to be silent in order for me to love you. I'm with you. I can take care of us."*

In my experience, when the internal struggles are lessened, the body can become calmer, and the sense of wholeness returns: I don't have to choose between a serious adult and a living child, but I can have both.

It's important to remember that the adults' reactions were their perceptions and the result of their own experiences. They are not the ultimate truth about me.

Before shame and prohibition took over, I knew how to feel joy, play, and feel good about myself. That ability never disappeared. It can be reclaimed gradually.

Mature Spontaneity

To be alive again does not mean to behave like a child everywhere.

Adults can take context into account. At home, you can bend and sing and fool around. On stage, you can talk openly and emotionally, while remembering the topic, the time and the people in front of you.

The right to be yourself does not abolish others' boundaries; the inner grounding does not absolve us from responsibility: it is important to hear the word "no," to notice the other person's reaction, and to correct when you have actually crossed the line.

For me, mature spontaneity is the freedom to be alive with the ability to choose form, and I don't suppress myself for fear of evaluation, but I don't justify disrespect by saying, "I'm just like that."

Now it's very simple. I can record a reels and leave a reservation, and I can't re-record a video three hundred times if I repeat a word or get lost in thought.

During the live broadcast I can say:

> *"Guys, I forgot that thought. I'll remember it in the next video."*

In a public speech, I can stutter, get better, and continue, and if necessary, apologize, but not humiliate myself.

Sometimes I publish a short thought without necessarily having to be expertly useful, and some people find it strange, some people respond, and it's not a judgment of my worth anymore.

One Small, Imperfect Action

You do not have to walk onto a large stage immediately to reclaim this lively part of yourself.

Try one possible action:

Post a short thought without making it a perfect post.

Make a short video about the weather or your day.

Dance at home without assessing your movements.

Tell your loved ones about your achievement without reducing it.

Share a simple personal story.

If you think “I’m stupid” or “I’ll be laughed at,” don’t rush to suppress them.

You could say:

> *"Yes, I have fear and shame in me now, but it's feelings, not judgment. I'm an adult and I can take a little step."*

Then look at reality. Maybe some people don't react, some people don't like it, and some people will be interested, but you don't have to leave yourself just because the reaction wasn't perfect.

The goal is not to violate your own boundaries again by forcing yourself to be seen at any cost. If you experience panic, a traumatic memory, or an overwhelming state, stop and seek appropriate support.

I know the return of the living part by its calmness and ease, sometimes it's warm in the body, and the thought of someone else's appreciation fades into the background, and it doesn't disappear forever, but it doesn't control every action.

I again enjoy the process of talking, moving, creating, joking and sharing.

Not because you have to like everyone, but because you don't have to reject yourself first.

What lively part of yourself did you once hide in order to seem easier, more proper, and more deserving of acceptance?

Chapter 12. A New Response, Tested in Real Life

After the inner workings, there comes a point where the changes need to be checked in real life.

You can understand a lot about your fear, find a childhood situation, notice an old alarm, get back into adulthood and feel an inner grounding, but one day you'll still have to do something you've avoided before: post a post, record a video, tell the cost of your work, or go out and tell people about yourself.

For me, this test was a performance on networking.

My First Talk After Working Through the Fear

The meeting was a circle format, and each participant talked about themselves and the problem they wanted to solve, and the others shared their ideas and their experiences.

My task was to develop my own project. In the past, I was afraid to say that I was a psychologist, a crisis psychologist, and a qualified professional. A voice would immediately rise inside me:

> *"What kind of psychologist are you? People are going to laugh and criticize and ask who you are."*

Before I spoke again, I was still worried that it would happen again, that my body would shrink again, my voice would sit down, and my hands would start to shake and sweat.

I started talking and felt like nothing was happening.

I calmly introduced myself as a crisis psychologist and an entrepreneur with twenty years of experience. I did not try to guess

what people would think of me. I did not expect an attack. I simply spoke about myself—freely and confidently.

At one point, a simple thought came up inside, "That's so cool. I can talk about myself and be myself."

Other People Had Not Changed

The people around them reacted calmly, much like they did before.

This became an important discovery: almost nothing around me had changed. My inner state had changed.

In previous networking sessions, people could just listen to me, but I expected ridicule, criticism, or criticism, and I got tense, noticed every look, and could mistake a smile for a reaction to what I said.

This time, I felt comfortable, and I even felt that people were listening with a lot of trust, and maybe that was just my impression, but when I was speaking calmly, it really felt different.

It wasn't that people suddenly became kinder, it was that I changed my attitude towards myself.

When Being Seen Becomes Interesting

After that meeting, I wanted to go to more events like this and talk more about myself, and the clamps, the discomfort and the constant anticipation of criticism were gone.

I started to enjoy socializing, and I felt like I was here as a person, and I could talk to people as equals, and I felt like I was finally a fish in the water.

No better than anyone, no worse. A normal person among ordinary people.

The next step was to join the business community, where regular networking is held, and after learning leadership school, participants can create their own mini-communities — small groups and interest meetings.

I became interested in more than simply attending. I wanted to bring people together, create connections, and develop topics that mattered to me. What once looked like frightening responsibility began to feel like a chance to express myself as a leader.

I began attending networking events twice a week. I enjoy introducing myself and talking about my work while feeling calm and free. What I once avoided has begun to bring me pleasure.

One new action brought the next.

Excitement and the Old Alarm Are Not the Same Thing

I may still have a little excitement before I speak, but that doesn't mean I have to wait for complete calm.

The difference is that the body is no longer in the same strong response: the hands are not shaking, the voice is not broken, there is no heavy compression inside.

> *“This is dangerous. They are about to reject, humiliate, or criticize you.”*

I start talking, and the excitement gradually fades, and it doesn't make me run away, or keep quiet, or prove my right to be among these people.

The big change for me is that I've embraced the opportunity to criticize, and if someone doesn't like what I say, they have the right to say what they say, but my value doesn't disappear.

I can get a little worried and still act.

Mistakes Are Material for Learning

The new state does not make a person an ideal speaker.

I may stutter, forget the thought, or not get the attention I'd like, and the workshop may not be as bright as I wanted, but now I don't infer that there's something wrong with me.

I finish my talk, and then I see what I can improve, somewhere I should be better prepared, somewhere I should be able to practice pitching, voice or work with the attention of the audience.

I have public-speaking skills and continue developing them. But professional skill and human worth are not the same thing.

It didn't work out perfectly, so I looked at what I could learn, and I went on, and one talk doesn't define me as a whole.

So, the mistake ceases to be a sentence and becomes a practice.

When Criticism Actually Comes

The test of life does not guarantee that everyone will only smile and support, but someone may ask an unpleasant question, laugh or openly disagree.

First of all, I try to notice what's going on inside, what's going on, what's going on, and how the body's going on, not to drive that reaction away, not to pretend that I don't care, but to give myself a few seconds to breathe in and breathe out.

It's important to remind ourselves that thoughts and feelings at this moment don't in themselves mean a real threat, and that other people's opinions don't determine my worth either.

If I don't know the answer, I can honestly say:

> *"I can't answer that right now. I'll get the information and come back to that later."*

If someone looks at the subject differently, I don’t need to argue immediately:

> *"You have a right to think that. I see it differently. We can talk about it after the talk."*

Then I continue the presentation.

For me, the inner grounding is here: I hear criticism, but I don’t have to attack, justify or disappear.

A Reflection Log: Before, During, and After

The first step for the reader is to make a short post or video about yourself:

> *"I'm so. I'm doing this. I can be of use to this."*

You can introduce yourself to a meeting, post a small reel or share one thought without trying to make the perfect material.

But it's not just about clicking the Publish button, it's about seeing your own reaction in three steps.

Before

Imagine that you have already gone out to people or posted a publication, and write down:

What thoughts have arisen;

What emotions are you experiencing?

where and how the body reacts;

What are you afraid you will feel about yourself—stupid, weak, small, rejected, or unwanted?

During

Notice what happens when you talk, you record a video, or you press a post button. Does the tension persist? Does it increase or gradually decrease? What are the thoughts that sound inside?

After

So again, write down your thoughts, your emotions, your body sensations, and look at the facts: what really happened, how people reacted, whether the scenario you expected came true.

But don't make someone else's reaction the main result of the test.

The key is to see yourself. Did the old alarm go off? Did you start feeling unworthy again? Or were you able to stay on the back, finish the action and maintain respect for yourself regardless of someone else's assessment?

And you can keep these records in your senses and bodily sensations, and they can help you see not just individual fear, but also changes from one attempt to another.

Repeat the Step, or Work with the Cause First?

What matters here is not the deadline, the number of talks that someone has given, the dynamics.

If with each attempt the tension is reduced a little bit and the action becomes easier and freer, the new experience helps. You can continue to practice and gradually complicate the task.

But if the fear remains as strong, intensifies, or makes you go through yourself every time, repetition alone may not be enough.

Especially when you're not just on stage, you're not talking at work, you're not protecting boundaries, you're avoiding conflict, you're afraid to talk about your values because you're going to be criticized, humiliated, rejected.

In this case, it is useful not to put pressure on yourself another attempt, but to carefully understand the cause of the reaction - independently within your capabilities or with a suitable specialist.

Your first step can be a journal. Notice the fear, the thoughts, the bodily reaction, and the painful image of yourself that lies behind them.

Then you can mentally address your little, once-rejected part:

> *"You're my part. I see you. I'm an adult now and I can be there for you."*

You don't have to eliminate fear immediately, you can stop fighting it, and then you can choose what you can do -- a short post, a little video, or a meeting.

Not to prove your confidence, but to test a new state of life.

What small action are you willing to take, regardless of the reaction of others?

Part IV. Practicing Visibility in Everyday Life

Chapter 13. Let Yourself Be Imperfect

For a long time I thought that it was only perfect.

If I'm making a video, I have to take away every pause and every caveat, and if I'm writing a post, it has to be profound, useful, and expert, and if I'm doing it, it's only in a way that nobody can find fault.

At first glance, this can look like a commitment to quality. But fear often stood behind it for me: What if people do not like it? What if it gets too few views? What if someone unfollows me or leaves a nasty comment?

And then the usual publication became an examination of my worth.

My First Imperfect Video

I remember the first time I decided not to make the railing perfect, and I got a little bit of noise while recording, and I got lost in one place, I mispronounced the word, and then I got better.

The first thought was familiar:

> *“You have to edit and cut everything.”*

And then I stopped and I said, Why? That's clear. I got better, and I kept talking. Why can't a person in a picture just stutter or get it wrong?

Of course, other thoughts immediately appeared:

> *"Someone won't like it right now. Criticism will start. Someone will unsubscribe."*

I felt a little tense before I posted it, but I said to myself, "Well, fine. Be the way I am. It's more important for me to be myself," and I posted the video without any further processing.

It became easier after publication.

And here is the interesting part: there were no hate comments. People reacted about the same way they had to the videos I used to polish endlessly. The number of views and likes was similar, and no one attacked me over one small flaw.

Fear pre-draws rejection and judgment, and reality is much calmer.

Did you do the same thing? Did you fix the stuff that was almost finished, not because it made no sense, but because you were afraid of being judged?

When One Video Becomes a Major Production

I used to take too long to create a short video, so I had to make a content plan, pick a topic, think through the video in detail, and lick the text.

Then take-offs started. There's too long a pause. I forgot the word. I didn't hold my phone in that place. The camera moved off a little bit. So you have to record it all over again.

I don't do studio videos, but I usually walk down the street and talk to the camera, and I like this live format, but I've tried to make it almost studio-like before.

Now, it's different. So the theme came in -- I went out and I could write down some rails in one walk, and before I write down, I know what I'm going to say, and I make a simple plan in my mind, but I don't have to go on and on.

Most of the videos I record the first time, and if the camera is off, the sound is gone, or I really lose the basic idea, of course I do, but a little pause or a caveat doesn't make me start over.

I didn't give up quality. I stopped confusing quality with perfection.

Quality or Perfectionism?

Now for me, quality is defined simply: did I get the message?

If I'm seriously lost, I'm missing the point, and I'm not covering the topic, it's worth re-recording, and the audience shouldn't know what I was trying to say.

But if the meaning is there and it's clear, little pauses, caveats, and imperfect intonation don't get in the way. It's something that can be published.

Perfectionism begins where the meaning is already communicated, but I keep fixing every little thing out of fear:

suddenly the video will seem insufficiently high quality;

And then the post gets very few views.

People will not sign up or start to unsubscribe.

I'm going to be criticized by someone.

I might be worse than other writers.

It’s especially easy to lose yourself when you start comparing your serve to someone else’s:

> *"He's got a better picture. She's more confident. They're more professional. So I should do the same."*

But I have a different voice, a different way of speaking, and a different experience, and there's no perfect pitch that everybody will

like, so I'm less and less focused on other psychologists' videos and more and more creating my own.

The key is to get the message across, and the rest can be improved incrementally without turning each video into a test of self-worth.

Not Every Post Has to Be Useful

I used to have resistance even when I wanted to put one short thought out.

> *"Just one line? Who cares? It's unprofessional. You have to open up the idea, make sure that people are valued and valued."*

So each publication had to prove something, whether it was my competence, my depth, or my usefulness, and just sharing what came to mind seemed insufficient.

I then allowed myself to post a normal life.

One of my first attempts was a simple video from a walk in the woods. There was no expert topic—I simply walked and showed what I saw. I worried a little: What if no one needs this? But people watched and left likes.

Another time, I posted a picture of the view from the window, of the beautiful trees and the first snow, and I just said I loved the first snow, and this post also resonated.

And then the thought of the day format came along, and one short thought, indiscriminately, and I expected people to say, "Why are you posting this? What's the use of this?"

So I reminded myself:

> *"This is my thought and my page. I can write here about things that are close to me, I don't force it on people or send it to them in private."*

Now I can publish a short video without speaking, film a beautiful tree, write a single line, or share myself dancing without extensive editing. Every post does not have to become a serious piece of expert content.

Let people see not only a specialist who is constantly teaching, but I am a living person.

Freedom Is Not Carelessness

It's important to not go to the other extreme, because being yourself doesn't mean, "I don't care about people, so I'll post anything."

I love what I do, and I want to share my knowledge, and if I talk about how to deal with resentment, fear, or inner discomfort, I want to understand the basic idea and see what the next step is, and my job is to talk about complex things in clear language.

Carelessness begins when I have not thought through what I want to say and the viewer has to assemble the meaning from fragments. A natural pause or slip of the tongue is different. If the idea is clear, why remake the video ten times and edit out everything human?

Before publishing, I check three things:

Is the main point understood and is it sufficiently disclosed?

Would an ordinary person understand the material? Have I used too many professional terms?

Is it possible to look or read the material calmly: is the voice well heard, is the image visible, is it not disturbed by extraneous noises?

If the meaning is clear, the language is available, and the technical quality does not interfere with perception, the material is ready.

That's where the line runs for me. I respect the time and the attention of the person, so I try to speak clearly and substantively, but I don't have to become perfect for that.

Publishing Is No Longer an Exam

When I allowed myself to appear alive, the page became much more enjoyable.

It’s really a thrill to express myself calmly and understand that even if someone doesn’t like my material, I can take it and continue my work.

Those who don't like my pitch can pass, and the people who respond to my thoughts, I'm glad, and the number of views and likes should no longer decide whether I have the right to speak.

I consider myself a professional in my work, but I don't have to be a great copywriter or a master of video editing. I can write sincerely, on my own, without the perfect packaging. In my experience, people respond to this kind of live feed.

Publishing used to be almost an exam. Now it's an opportunity to be yourself.

The “Simple and Easy” Practice

Try to record the simplest video today – without expert topic and long preparation.

For example:

> *"I'm in a good mood today. Are you guys in a good mood?"*

Or:

"What a nice weather today! Let's just celebrate this day."

You can say nothing at all. You see a beautiful tree, you take a short video and post it, you notice an unusual sign, you show it, and you say, "What's the name for it?"

If you don’t want to record a video, write a short post: one thought, one observation, or one phrase about your condition.

The main purpose of this practice is not to produce useful or perfect content. It is to let yourself create and be visible with more ease.

What to Do with the Tension

Before publishing, pay attention to your thoughts, feelings and sensations in the body.

What's inside?

"Nobody wants that."

"I'm going to look stupid."

"I'm going to be laughed at."

Where is the tension? What do you feel, fear, shame, anxiety?

You don't have to drive that reaction away. You can admit, "Yeah, I'm worried right now. My body is straining because I'm going to do something different."

It helps me to imagine holding myself. Perhaps these feelings belong to the younger part of me that once felt rejected, hurt, or not good enough. I picture that child, accept him as part of me, and say:

"I'm with you. You don't have to disappear. We're safe now."

I don't suppress thoughts and feelings, and I don't try to become fearless, and when the internal struggles are lessened, you can press the "publish" button, not because the anxiety is supposed to

disappear completely, but because I don't have to run away from it anymore.

After you post, notice your condition again. There may have been tension before, and then there is often a lightness: I did what I wanted, and nothing bad happened.

If people respond warmly, it's nice, but the main thing is that you've allowed yourself to come out.

When There Are Few Views or Hate Comments

One video, one comment, and a small number of views do not determine your value or your professionalism.

You can tell yourself:

> *"My content doesn't have to be liked by everyone. I keep looking for my audience and my pitch."*

If you're just expressing a different opinion, you don't have to fight.

> *“I understand that this point of view exists. Thank you for sharing it.”*

If a comment turns into an insult and violates your page's rules, you have the right to delete it and block the user.It doesn't mean you can't stand criticism.You just control your space and set boundaries.

Feedback can be studied. Who am I writing for? What does it matter to these people? What questions do they want to understand? But audience interests need to be aligned with what is valuable to you, not to be lost in the expectations of others.

Keep writing, shooting and publishing, not to please everyone, but to gradually find people who are close to your topic and your actual pitch.

What would you publish today if you didn’t have to do it perfectly or prove your worth?

Chapter 14. Talking About Your Work and Naming Your Price

You can learn to write posts, record videos, and talk about your work with confidence, but then there comes a point where you say,

> *“The cost of my service is such and such.”*

And sometimes it is on this phrase that all confidence disappears somewhere.

The voice grows quieter and the body contracts. Then you want to justify the price, offer a discount immediately, or retreat altogether. In that moment, the person is not merely naming a number. Inside, it feels as if they are answering the question, “How much am I worth?”

The 20,000-Ruble Package

About three years ago, I was taking a social media development course where we were learning to package services and sell counseling packages.

I decided to offer four consultations for 20,000 rubles, which I don't think is a lot now, but it was scary to say it back then, and before that, one of my consultations cost an average of about two thousand rubles.

I would invite people to a free diagnostic meeting, sort out their situation, and then I would offer them a job, and it would follow a script, and I would explain what they needed to work with, and then I would say,

> *“Further work will cost 20 thousand rubles.”*

And that's where the most interesting thing started.

The voice sat down a little, the body shrank, the confidence dropped, and before the client answered, the inside sounded like,

> *"He'll refuse now."*
>
> *"He'll say it's too expensive."*
>
> *“He’ll ask why your work is so worth so much and you can’t explain it.”*

Then came the inner critic:

> *"What kind of expert are you to call that price? Are you already so experienced? Why do you have to be paid that much?"*

So I was making a pre-excuse for the cost, and the price didn't sound like an offer that a person could accept or reject, but a statement that I had yet to prove my claim to.

You know, you know, they gave you a sum, and I wanted to explain to you why you're not asking too much.

I Was Afraid of Both Rejection and Acceptance

About eight out of ten people refused, and two agreed to buy the package.

After the rejection, I said to myself:

> *"You have to lower the price. No one will buy with that money. You don't have enough experience. You shouldn't have said that amount."*

But the customer's consent was not entirely relieving, and instead of fear of selling, there was fear of the outcome.

> *“What if the customer is unhappy?”*

> *“What if he says the consultation went badly and asks for a refund?”*
>
> *“Now I have to have four meetings so that the person will get the result.”*

I feared both outcomes. I interpreted a refusal as proof that my work was not worth the price. I interpreted acceptance as a dangerous obligation that I might fail to fulfill.

The question of price was: do I have the right to receive such money if I can not guarantee a certain result in advance?

A Story That Seemed to Confirm My Fear

One client chose two coaching sessions for 10,000 rubles instead of the full package. We completed both meetings, and afterward she stopped responding.

I don't know what exactly happened, and she may have faced internal resistance and she didn't want to go on, but that's just my guess, because the client didn't explain anything.

I was working as a coach at the time, and I wasn't a psychologist yet, and I think the meetings were good, but the work stopped after two sessions.

Then I heard inside:

> *“You see, you couldn’t get the customer to the bottom.”*

That single incident carried more weight for my fear than all the other facts. No one had requested a refund, and other clients continued working with me. But my mind seized on the one story that confirmed my old self-doubt.

Now, I look at these situations differently, and when I'm dissatisfied or when I'm out of work, I need to look at the facts, what I've been

able to do, what I can do better, and where my client's responsibility begins, but they don't make me a bad or unworthy professional.

What Actually Depends on the Professional

My job is to help a person formulate a clear, achievable goal that relates to himself.

For example, a customer says,

I want to get rid of the fear of public speaking.

It tells you what he wants to get away from, but it doesn't tell you what he wants to be, and the goal is, you can specify:

I want to feel comfortable and comfortable in public speaking.

Then I build the work, ask questions, suggest techniques, and lead the person in a particular structure, and I'm responsible for my training, my professional framework, the quality of the meeting, and the honest description of the method.

The client is responsible for his own purpose, participation, decisions and actions, and I cannot change his life in his place, force him to continue working or abandon his usual beliefs.

In my experience, change is more likely when a person is engaged in the process and willing to work with themselves. But this cannot guarantee the same result for everyone.

The boundary of responsibility does not mean indifference, but it means that I do everything that really depends on me, and I do not promise what is in the hands of another person.

The terms of work, payment, rescheduling of meetings and possible returns are important to specify in advance and clearly in the contract, then difficult situations are solved not out of fear and guilt, but on the basis of agreed terms.

What the Client Is Paying For

The client doesn't just come to talk, he seeks professional help in moving toward his goal.

The cost consists of several parts:

Helping to set a clear and realistic goal

professional support;

method and structure of work;

knowledge, education and practical experience of a specialist;

Time and attention during the session.

My meeting usually lasts from an hour to an hour and a half, sometimes longer depending on the task and format.

Of course, people pay in the hope of change, but they pay for professional work that is focused on results, not guaranteed results, regardless of their own participation.

When I understand clearly what service I offer, what I am responsible for, and where the limits of my responsibility lie, it becomes easier to name the price.

When Asking Feels Dangerous

But a logical explanation alone was not enough. My fear around money had begun long before my first sale.

I grew up in a poor family, and I didn't get any pocket money, and if I had any money, my mom would take it with the words,

> *“Give it to me, I know how to spend it.”*

It was not safe to ask for anything, and I heard, "There's no money," and if I kept asking or being naughty, I could be scared of being given to the Gypsies, or punished.

Gradually, I almost stopped asking for anything. A connection had formed inside me: wanting and asking were dangerous. It felt safer to stay quiet, demand nothing, and avoid creating problems for adults.

And it also made me feel like I wasn't worthy of gifts, new things, and care, and even a good attitude seemed like something to be earned by the right behavior.

The broader culture of the time also mattered. In the Soviet environment, wealthy people were often viewed with suspicion: they must have stolen the money, been involved in crime, or traded purely for profit. Words such as “profiteer” and “speculator” were used as insults.

Another image was approved: an honest worker who lived like everyone else, didn't stand out and didn't want to earn much more than everyone else, and as a child I absorbed these notions without checking them, money was associated not only with scarcity, but also with shame, wanting more, selling and earning well, it was like it was wrong.

An Adult Client, a Child’s Reaction

When the client said "expensive," I felt stupid and unworthy of the money, as if the amount was proving that I had too much of a self-image.

There were old phrases inside:

> *"You've got everything."*
>
> *“We will not buy anything new.”*

"No money."

As a child, I felt guilty about the request, and it seemed that my desires were creating more problems for the family, and as an adult, it was different: I didn't ask my mom for a new thing, I said the cost of my work, but inside I was experiencing almost the same thing.

When a client said, “That is too expensive for me,” I heard:

"You're not worthy of that money. Your job isn't worth that much. You asked for something extra."

As long as a customer's decision determines your personal value, no sales script will give you real peace of mind. You can learn the right words, but a voice will still betray inner doubt.

Reclaiming the Right to Receive

It was a very difficult subject for me to work on, but gradually I saw that my mother's attitude was not the truth about me.

Another adult might hug, support, or at least say:

"You are important to me. You are worthy of care and love."

My mother could not give me that support at the time. Her response reflected her own attitude, abilities, and view of the world. As a child, I took it personally and concluded, “If I am treated this way, I must be unwanted and unworthy.”

The very feeling of childhood was real and understandable, but the conclusion that I had drawn at the time was not objectively true about me.

In my inner work, I would go back to my little self, accepting the fear, the pain, the desire to be cared for, and I would remember the condition before these grades, when I was just living, playing,

enjoying, and not yet dividing myself into the worthy and the unworthy.

Then I would go through my previous experiences as an adult who could stay close to me, and I would reclaim the inner grounding of the feeling that I was important and valuable to myself first and foremost.

Now I'm calling the price calmly and even with pleasure, and I'm putting out terms that are appropriate for me and are consistent with how much time, attention and professional effort I put in.

If someone says no, my inner state does not collapse. Perhaps the price, format, timing, or I as a professional are not the right fit. We can part calmly. Their decision does not mean that my terms are wrong or that something is wrong with me.

A Calm Statement, Not Pressure

Now I can tell the client:

> *“If you are ready to address this issue and commit the necessary time and resources, I am ready to help. Here is the format, the length of each meeting, and the price.”*

I honestly tell you how I work, I name the terms and I leave the person the choice, and I don't have to hold on to it, coax it, or lure it.

People choose a psychologist not only because of their education and their methods, but because they care about their communication style, their trust and their personal sense of contact, and I realize that I don't have to be a good fit for everyone.

My job is to offer help clearly, and the decision to buy is up to the customer.

Practice: Name Your Price and Stay Present for the Answer

First, imagine a conversation about selling and write down:

What thoughts arise before the name of the price;

where tension appears in the body;

What a feeling behind him?

What are you afraid you will feel—rejected, unworthy, weak, or unwanted?

When you first experienced a similar condition.

You don't have to just throw out those thoughts or replace them with positive ones, but you can mentally support that little part of yourself that was once embarrassed to want and ask:

> *"I see you. You're my part. I'm an adult now and I can be there. The other person's decision no longer determines my worth."*

If the memories or bodily reactions become too strong, don’t force yourself to go deeper.

Then you go to the outside exercise, and you say the real thing a few times, calmly.

> *"The format includes four consultations. The package cost is 20 thousand rubles."*

Tell me your real service and your real price.

Do not justify the amount, do not urgently list diplomas and do not offer a discount just because the interlocutor took a pause.

If a person is in doubt, you can clarify:

“What exactly is stopping you right now?”

“Do you have any questions about the format or content of the work?”

“Do you need time to make a decision?”

One quiet question helps us understand the reason for the doubt, but it should not turn into pressure, and if after the explanation the person says no, the decision must be respected.

Your service will not be bought by everyone. It will be chosen by those who need it now, who fit your format and who are willing to get involved.

The job of the professional is not to reach agreement at all costs, but to clearly state the benefits, format and cost, answer questions and maintain respect for themselves and the client regardless of their decision.

How do you feel right now when you imagine that you are calmly telling a person the true value of your work and no longer justifying it?

Chapter 15. Criticism, Silence, and the Skill of Being Seen

When someone finally decides to become visible, they often wait for confirmation through views, likes, comments, or gratitude.

He was afraid, prepared, worked with himself, pressed the Publish button, and now it’s as if he’s asking the world:

> *"How did I do it? Am I allowed in now?"*

And sometimes there's silence.

And that silence can hurt no less than criticism.

One or Two Views

My first videos sometimes got one or two views.

I did my best. I took a course in the making of a rail, I made up scripts, I made small scenes, I put in time and effort, and I got almost nothing back.

I wanted to give up everything.

I had thoughts in my head:

> *“No one needs that kind of content.”*

> *“No one is interested in me as a specialist.”*

> *“I don’t know how to make good videos.”*

I looked at other bloggers, they had interesting videos, views, likes and comments, and I tried to do something similar, but I still had almost no reaction.

The number of views stopped being information about one particular video. I turned it into a judgment about myself and began to feel stupid, uninteresting, and unwanted.

It was a painful ligament.

> *“If my content is not watched, then I am a bad specialist and no one needs me.”*

You recognize yourself? You published it, you checked the statistics a few times, and then you came to a conclusion about your own worth, not your video?

A Year of Finding the Right Focus

This continued for about a year. I worked with my insecurity and my painful feelings of being unwanted and unworthy while continuing to search for the right subject.

I thought: if the videos are not watched, then the topic is wrong, I say the wrong thing or do it wrong.

I probably changed direction four times, and I see something popular, and I think, "This is on the hype right now, I'll try to talk about it," but the result was almost unchanged.

I bought courses in copywriting, reels, scripts, public speaking and speaking, and I seemed to be constantly lacking another skill, the right scheme, or a more popular topic.

And then I realized, I need to create my own content, talk about what I'm really interested in, what I know, and what I want to learn next.

It doesn't mean that you'll get a response right away, but now I can go on, because I like the content, and I'm not just talking about my topic for the numbers, but because I think it's important.

For me, the main thing was not to find another hype, but first to find myself.

What Do Low View Counts Really Mean?

One or two views don't prove that the author is not wanted, they only say that the particular material has not received attention.

The reasons can be found in the content itself.

Is the topic in demand? Is it related to the pain, desire, or dream of the audience?

Does the headline make sense? Does it give a person a reason to stop?

Is there a thought in the first seconds that holds your attention?

Is the subject covered? Is the pitch too complicated or too confusing?

Statistics can provide feedback about a particular piece of content. I can change the title, structure, opening, or explanation. I do not have to remake my whole identity along with the video.

Fact: The video got very few views.

Interpretation: No one wants me.

It's not the same thing.

Useful Feedback, Disagreement, and Devaluation

Not all comments have the same value.

A useful feedback often looks like a question:

> *"How do you know that?"*

“Can you explain this idea in more detail?”

"What do you do in a situation like this?"

And you can see that the person is engaged and interested in the topic, and I may not have explained a particular point clearly enough, or I may have touched on a question that is worth continuing.

There is also a supportive response:

"Thank you, I got a response."

"That's just me."

"I'll try to apply it."

It shows that the material reached someone and mattered to them.

The usual disagreement is not an attack, everyone has their own experience, worldview and values, and if a person writes, "I don't agree with you," I can thank them for their opinion and ask them how they view the question.

That's how you get a meaningful conversation sometimes, but I don't have to convince the other person at all costs.

Devaluation sounds different:

"You're writing some nonsense."

There's no specific question or argument in a message, you can ask a person once to explain a position, but if the conversation turns into a pointless argument, I don't put myself into it anymore.

If there are a few similar questions under the video, I will use them as material for new content:

"This question came up in the comments. Let's go into it in more detail."

Useful feedback helps the work develop. Devaluation tries to stop the work altogether.

Comments That Used to Knock Me Down

One day, under my material, they wrote:

> *"You wrote all the nonsense and nonsense. You must have psychological problems yourself."*

Another time I talked about working with internal psychological discomfort, a reader deliberately misrepresented my words and left a mocking comment about physical pain and intimate problems.

I said calmly:

> *"I'm talking about psychological discomfort. I'm not a doctor, so you should see a medical professional for physical pain."*

In the past, a sentence like that could still knock me off balance. My body contracted, I felt weak, and it seemed that I could not defend myself.

Behind that rude sentence, I heard more than disagreement. I heard rejection and the message that I did not matter—as if the person were rejecting not one post, but all of me.

One other person’s comment was becoming more important than the rest of my reactions and my own attitude toward myself.

Where Criticism Ends and a Boundary Violation Begins

If you react to a story, it's possible that something has affected you, that an attack may be anger, resentment, shame, or some other unpleasant feeling, but you can't know exactly what's going on inside you from a comment.

So I try not to make a diagnosis, but to ask a direct question:

> *“What exactly offended you in my words?”*
>
> *"What thought do you disagree with?"*
>
> *“Can you explain your position without going personal?”*

Sometimes it helps to move from attack to conversation.

If a person continues to insult, provokes an argument and turns to personalities, I no longer try to convince them, I block the user or stop responding.

My page is a space where I have the right to set boundaries, where disagreement, questions and arguments are acceptable, and I don't have to tolerate constant insults.

As they say, “Dogs bark, the caravan is coming.”

I can hear useful criticism, but I don’t have to stop because of every person who decides to hurl aggression at me.

Pictures in Someone Else’s Head

I now let people have their own opinions about me and my content.

Everyone looks at my videos through their experiences, beliefs and values, and from that they create a certain image of the author, their picture of me.

But this picture is not me.

One person will see a useful idea. Another person will disagree. A third person will get annoyed. They all read the same material, but they perceive it differently.

I don’t have to get into someone else’s head, correct my image there, and make a person treat me in a certain way.

I have my views and my values. The other person has his. We may not match.

Other people's opinions don't have to become my self-esteem anymore, I can hear them, respond to them when I need them, and continue to do my thing, and I can stand by my side.

Being Seen Is the Skill of Continuing

One video that's been posted doesn't make you a habit of showing up, but it's when you keep talking and acting after different audience reactions.

I love to talk about the inner grounding method and how it can be useful, and I study psychology, and I keep working with myself, and I notice changes in my life and in my work with people.

I look at the questions people come up with, and I create content based on them, and I want to encourage subscribers to send in their queries to record individual videos about situations that they can't yet solve on their own.

This content is linked to my values, and through it I share knowledge and express myself.

So the lack of comment doesn't negate the meaning of my work, and sometimes the inspiration goes away, but the interest in the topic stays, and I go back to it.

When Inspiration Is Not There

In those moments, it's not the pressure that helps me, it's the meaning.

Sometimes I feel like a vessel filled to the brim. I study, reflect, and test a great deal in my own life. The knowledge I have gathered

needs an outlet. When I share what I have understood, space opens for new experience.

If the topic doesn’t come up on its own, I ask myself:

> *"What else can I give people?"*
>
> *"What thought should I explain?"*
>
> *"What question can I answer?"*

But not every publication has to be educational, and sometimes I share a thought, a walk, a break, a little bit of life.

So, it's not just about inspiration that makes me feel more like I can prepare useful material, answer a question, or just show a real moment.

A Practice for Silence or Criticism

After a weak view or a nasty comment, stop and write down four points.

The Facts

What happened without grades?

> *"The video got two views."*
>
> *“The man wrote that he disagreed.”*
>
> *"There's no comment under the post."*

The Automatic Thought

What did you decide about yourself?

> *“No one wants my content.”*
>
> *"I'm not an interesting specialist."*
>
> *"I'm not gonna make it."*

Fact and interpretation are different things.

Feelings and the Body

What do you feel: fear, shame, anger, resentment or frustration? Where does it feel in your body? Chests tightened, throat strained, hands down? Want to delete the publication or write nothing more?

This reaction can be disassembled by the Inner Grounding Method: notice a painful image of yourself, accept feelings and regain a sense of self-worth and security.

The Next Step

Ask yourself:

> *"Why am I doing this?"*
>
> *“Is the expression related to my values?”*
>
> *“Do I want to share my knowledge even if the reaction is not immediate?”*

If the desire remains, choose one feasible step: record the next video, answer a question, change the title or reveal the topic in more detail.

You don't have to wait for the excitement to disappear completely. You have to get back enough support so that the action doesn't become violence.

How to Know the Skill Is Growing

One of the main signs is that pleasure is already in the process.

You make a video, it's interesting to talk. You write a post, you like to formulate a thought. You publish it, you feel satisfied that you did something important to yourself.

Instead of waiting for evaluation, a more relaxed state comes:

"Someone will come in, some won't. There will be likes -- fine. There won't be -- I did what I liked anyway."

The body changes as well. It becomes freer and less rigid. The voice grows calmer, and speech flows more smoothly. You no longer have to guess the audience's reaction every second.

It doesn't mean that the person stops worrying or noticing the weak views, but the discomfort no longer controls their actions.

After a failed publication, he looks at what can be improved, and he goes on. After a nasty comment, he doesn't have to disappear or engage in an endless argument.

You showed up, enjoyed the process, and moved on.

Come Back to Yourself

The main idea I want to leave to the reader is to return to myself, to that inner free person who was before criticism, judgment and constant evaluation.

A child once simply wanted to live, play, experiment, express himself, and feel joy. He did not divide every action into right and wrong or constantly ask:

"What will they think of me?"

For me, it is a state of true self: I know what I want, accept and approve of myself, feel inner security, and can act out of a living desire – "I want to do it."

Old fears, humiliation, rejection, criticism and the habit of seeing yourself through other people's eyes can stand in the way, and it's important to see these obstacles, stop fighting them, and gradually reclaim the part of yourself that you once had to give up.

A person can then stop living to earn love, approval, or the right to be themselves. They can rely on the self-respect that already exists within.

And it's not just about posts, videos, or public speaking, it's about life.

I can choose my goals and desires, not just to do what is expected of me, and I don't have to prove my worth endlessly, seek safety in external approval, or become comfortable to be accepted.

Criticism may come. There may be silence in response to a publication, and some people will pass by and some people will feel close to me, but none of these reactions determine whether I am entitled to continue.

I can live from an inner grounding: to feel valued, needed and important to myself, to be who I am, to enjoy life, to speak with my voice and to be on my side.

For me, freedom begins here.

What action are you willing to take today, not for the sake of evaluation, but because it is truly yours?

Conclusion: Allow yourself to be yourself

When I first tried to make myself visible, I thought I had to become confident, get rid of fear, earn another degree, and learn to speak perfectly before I could face an audience.

But the longer I prepared, the further I put off real life.

I studied, took courses, changed direction, and came up with new names for new projects. Yet one thought often hid behind all that preparation: “I am still not good enough.”

I understand now that the fear of being seen is not always about the stage, the camera, a post, or a conversation. Beneath it often lies something deeper: the feeling that something is wrong with me—that people may mock me, reject me, or see me as stupid or unwanted.

The body responds to these thoughts as if they signal real danger. The throat tightens, the voice weakens, the palms sweat, and words become tangled. You want to postpone the post, turn down the talk, or go back to studying yet again.

At one time, this reaction may truly have helped you adapt and preserve your connection with important adults. But you are no longer the small child whose life depends on someone else’s approval.

You are an adult. You can tolerate another person’s disagreement. You can make a mistake and correct it. You can hear criticism without falling apart. Someone can dislike you, and you can still continue living your life.

Inner Grounding Is Not Perfect Calm

Inner grounding does not mean that you will never feel nervous, have doubts, or make mistakes again.

Some nervousness before an important talk is perfectly natural. An old thought may flash through your mind, or tension may return for a few seconds. The difference is that you no longer disappear into that state completely.

You can notice the reaction, make room for it, and return to yourself:

> *“Yes, I am nervous. And I am still okay.”*
>
> *“Yes, I may make a mistake. That does not make me a bad person.”*
>
> *“Yes, someone may dislike what I say. That does not change my worth.”*

Inner grounding does not arrive when the whole world finally approves of you. It appears when you stop giving the world the right to decide who you are.

To Be Seen Is to Be Alive

Being seen is not limited to public speaking, Reels, or social media posts.

It is the ability to talk about yourself without guilt. To name the price of your work. To ask for help. To disagree with your boss. To protect your boundaries. To offer an idea. To introduce yourself to someone. To admit what you truly want.

At its heart, being seen means taking part in your own life.

You can remain unnoticed for years, trying not to upset or disappoint anyone. But when you hide the fear, you also hide your abilities, desires, knowledge, and energy.

I waited far too long for the moment when I would feel completely ready. Now I see that readiness does not always come before action. It also grows while you act.

You record your first video. You publish a post. You attend a meeting. You talk about your work. You name your price. You make a mistake, correct it, and continue.

This is how a new experience takes shape: I allowed myself to be seen, and I remained safe.

Your Next Step

You do not need to change your entire life in a single day after finishing this book.

Choose one situation in which the fear of being seen is getting in your way right now.

Ask yourself:

What do I want to do but keep postponing?

What thoughts appear before I take this step?

What is happening in my body?

What is the worst thing I expect to happen?

What am I afraid I will feel about myself?

Whose voice might I be hearing inside?

Is this truly dangerous for the adult I am today?

Do not suppress the answers or argue with yourself. Simply notice them. If an image of your younger, frightened, or rejected self appears, stay beside that child in your mind.

Say:

> *“I am here with you. You are safe. I accept you. I am the adult now, and I can take care of us.”*

Then take one small step—not for likes, approval, or proof of your worth. Take it for yourself.

Record a short video. Publish one thought. Talk about your work. Ask a question. Name your price. Express your opinion.

Afterward, notice your body and your thoughts again. Do not judge yourself by the outcome. Notice what matters most: you took the step and remained yourself.

First, Win Your Own Heart

You cannot be liked by everyone. One person may find you interesting, another may find you ordinary, and a third may feel that you are simply not the right fit. That is normal.

If you continually define yourself through other people’s opinions, you can lose touch with yourself entirely.

So the first task is not to win over an audience, a client, or the whole world. It is to win back your own heart—your love, respect, acceptance, and trust in yourself.

It took me time to understand this. I do not allow myself to be seen because I have stopped being an ordinary human being. I can still make a mistake, forget a word, record an imperfect video, or hear no.

The difference is that one event no longer defines who I am.

I remain valuable, important, and worthy of my own care. From that place, I can learn, correct mistakes, grow, and continue my work.

If this book helps you take even one step that you once postponed because you feared someone else's judgment, then our conversation has mattered.

What step are you willing to take now—not for approval, but because it truly matters to you?